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# BR Shetty sues BoB for $15 Billion

**J GOPIKRISHNAN** ■ New Delhi




In a bizarre move, NRI industrialist BR Shetty filed a legal suit of $15 billion (₹1.44 lakh crore) in the Bombay High Court against Bank of Baroda (BoB) and its top officials and his ex-CEOs for conniving, leading to the collapse of NMC Healthcare, headquartered in Abu Dhabi. Debt sunken Shetty's move came within three months after BoB paid ₹5,700 crore, after it was found violating anti-money laundering norms by Abu Dhabi Global Market Courts (ADGMC). BoB was facing the charges in an insolvency case of NMC Healthcare in Abu Dhabi and London courts from 2020.

On July 2, BoB declared to Stock Exchanges that it decided on pay ₹5,700 crore without admitting any guilt in a bid to close long time legal case in foreign courts. Citing the judgment of the Abu Dhabi Court, *The Pioneer* on August 3 reported that Bank of Baroda was accused for violating anti-money laundering norms. In court proceedings, Shetty accused his CEO Prasanth Manghat for conniving with BoB's officials, leading to such a huge financial burden during 2012-2020 operations.

The Administrators of Insolvency in ADGMC alleged that BoB's Abu Dhabi branch facilitated financing arrangements and banking transactions that allowed NMC Healthcare and related 37 entities to conceal their actual financial position. They also claimed that the bank failed to carry out adequate Anti-Money Laundering (AML), Know-Your-Customer (KYC) and due diligence checks, contributing to the continuation of the alleged fraud.

"Claims are brought against Bank of Baroda based on allegations that it acted fraudulently and without proper care in contract (under Article 246 of the Civil Code) and in tort (under Articles 282 and 285 of the Civil Code). Secondly, there are the so-called "insolvency claims", which are made by the Joint Administrators under Section 251 of the ADGM Insolvency Regulations 2022 (the "IR 2022") in fraudulent trading against Shetty, Manghat and Bank of Baroda, and under Section 252 of the IR 2022 in wrongful trading against Shetty and Manghat. For present purposes, it is the civil claims that are relevant: it is common ground that they are all governed by UAE law. The insolvency claims are governed by ADGM law," said the Judgment of Justice Sir Andrew Smith of Abu Dhabi Global Market (ADGM) Court of First Instance Commercial and Civil Division, dated March 25, 2025.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

# Nobody can browbeat judiciary: CJI

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE** ■ New Delhi



Taking a serious view of Rahul Gandhi's protest march to the Supreme Court on Monday, Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant warned on Thursday that "Nobody can browbeat the judiciary."

Making this observation while listening to petitions by Rahul Gandhi and other INDIA bloc leaders regarding SIR, the bench, headed by the CJI and comprising Justice Joymalya Bagchi, issued notice to the Election Commission of India (ECI) but added that serving notice does not mean condoning the conduct of the political leaders. The bench was hearing various pleas related to the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, Delhi protests, march to the Supreme Court and alleged assault on journalists and lawyers on Thursday.

The court's observations came after Solicitor General Tushar Mehta and advocate Gaurav Bhatia raised the issue of the protest at the Supreme Court. "It is unacceptable that this court is seized with political procession. What happened in SC should not have happened," Bhatia pointed out. At this point, the CJI stated: "Nobody can browbeat the judiciary."

On Bhatia's assertion that the protest and protest march were an attempt to pressurise the court, the CJI called the attempts "feeble". "These are feeble attempts that nobody takes note of. Outside they make statements... We are not sitting in ivory towers. We know what statements they make outside and what they say in court. We know everything," the CJI observed. The bench, however, did not name the petitioner.

The observation assumes significance as one of the state units of the Congress recently sought the CJI's resignation while commenting on his observations that the law and order fall under the executive domain.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

# CJP's Tricolour march faces police curbs

**ABHINAV KUMAR JHA** ■ New Delhi

The Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) plan to march with Tricolours at Central Park in Connaught Place on Friday may not get off the ground. The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) has shut the park to the public on October 16 and 17 for "administrative reasons", and Delhi Police has told people to stay away, saying prohibitory orders under Section 163 of the BNSS are already in force in the area.

The NDMC said in a notice dated October 15 that the park would stay closed on October 16 and 17 "due to administrative reasons". The NDMC director issued the notice. The closure falls on the day the CJP has called people to the park at 5 pm with Tricolour flags.

The civic body has also told Delhi Police about the closure. Police said in a statement on Thursday that it has asked for adequate security to prevent unauthorised access to the park. Police said Section 163 of the BNSS is already in force in Connaught Place and adjoining areas to maintain peace and protect lives and property. The statement said police would take legal action against those who defy the orders. People were urged to cooperate.

CONTINUED ON >> P4






# SC draws line on caste quotas after conversion

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE** ■ New Delhi

In a significant verdict, the Supreme Court on Thursday held that a Hindu belonging to a backward class could not claim the same reservation benefits as a Muslim member of a backward class merely on conversion to Islam. The court also said that a person professing a religion other than Hinduism, Sikhism, or Buddhism cannot be considered a member of a Scheduled Caste. The ruling highlights how religious conversion affects eligibility for caste-based reservation and legal protections.



A bench of Justices Prashant Kumar Mishra and Shree Chandrashekhar clarified the law while dismissing a Tamil Nadu Government appeal seeking confirmation of the State's policy to provide reservation benefits to members of backward classes, most backward classes, denotified communities and scheduled castes who embrace Islam.

"No statutory benefit, protection, reservation, or other entitlement under Article 16(4) of the Constitution, the enjoyment of which is predicated upon a particular Hindu social order, can be claimed or extended merely based on such antecedent membership after the person has converted to Islam, Christianity, or any other non-Hindu social order," the bench held.

It said the court concluded that a person who converts from the Hindu social order to a non-Hindu social order cannot claim affirmative action under Article 16(4) of the Constitution merely because of the social backwardness associated with his pre-conversion status.

"A backwardness suffered in the antecedent social order cannot by itself be carried forward to confer upon him the status of a backward class in the region to which he has converted...," it said.

CONTINUED ON >> P4




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# Capital to install one lakh smart street lights, fix 48-hour repair deadline

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi




Agencies responsible for maintaining Delhi's street lights will face a penalty of ₹2,000 per light for every day of delay beyond a 48-hour repair deadline, under a new project to install one lakh smart LED lights across the Capital.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta launched the initiative at Andrews Ganj on Thursday, saying it would address dark spots and improve safety for women and other road users. The project follows concerns raised by female students during her recent interaction at Delhi University about poorly lit stretches in the city.

Under the plan, the status of individual lights will be monitored in real time through a central command centre. Each light will carry a QR code that residents can scan to access information and register complaints. The Government has set a target of keeping 99 per cent of the lights functional.

The Public Works Department will oversee the system, which will also include smart feeder pillars to improve monitoring and control. The project covers installation as well as maintenance, including action in cases of theft and vandalism.

Around 45,000 existing high-pressure sodium vapour lamps will be replaced with energy-efficient LED lights. The Government expects the shift, along with smart scheduling, to reduce electricity consumption and generate savings of around ₹100 crore over five years.

The system will adjust illumination according to the time of day, increasing brightness in the evening and reducing it in the morning. The Government said the technology would help improve lighting while controlling energy costs.

The Chief Minister said the initiative was intended to make Delhi's roads and public spaces safer and ensure that women could travel more confidently after dark.

She said the Government was using technology to improve public services and strengthen accountability in street-light maintenance.

The project sets illumination standards for different types of roads. Average lighting levels are to be maintained at 35 lux on main roads and 25 lux on service roads for seven years. The lights will have a colour temperature of 3,000 kelvin and a minimum luminous efficacy of 150 lumens per watt.

The Government said these specifications would help ensure consistent lighting quality and improve visibility for road users, including in foggy conditions.

The 48-hour repair deadline is intended to address a key weakness in the existing system, under which real-time information about faulty lights is not available. With the new arrangement, faults are expected to be identified more quickly, while the penalty provision will make agencies accountable for delays.

The project will be rolled out across various Assembly constituencies, beginning with Andrews Ganj.

The Government has described it as part of its broader effort to improve basic civic infrastructure through technology and more effective monitoring.

PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said the smart lighting system would improve visibility on roads and help make night-time travel safer.

He said monitoring each light would help authorities identify breakdowns and ensure repairs were completed on time. New Delhi MP Bansuri Swaraj and several MLAs, including Satish Upadhyay, Shikha Rai, Anil Sharma and Neeraj Basoya, attended the launch.

# 1,505 applicants for 522 Dwarka Golf Course memberships

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



More than 1,500 applicants are competing for 522 lifetime memberships at the Dwarka Golf Course, and the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) will decide the successful candidates through a draw of lots on Friday. The draw will take place at 11 am on October 16 at the Auction Hall in D-Block, DDA Vikas Sadan, INA.

The authority will conduct separate draws for Government and non-Government applicants and make the proceedings available through a live YouTube webcast.

According to the DDA, 1,505 eligible applicants have been identified for the memberships. Of these, 392 are competing for 53 places under the Government category, while 1,113 applicants are in the running for 469 places under the non-Government category.

The numbers mean there are more than seven applicants for every available government-category membership, compared with around 2.4 applicants for each non-Government slot.

The membership scheme was introduced on the directions of Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu.

The DDA said it had received an enthusiastic response from applicants. Those unable to attend the draw in person can follow it online.

The live broadcast will be available on YouTube, allowing applicants to watch the selection process remotely.

The cost of membership varies by category and duration. A lifetime membership costs ₹3.5 lakh for Government applicants and ₹7.5 lakh for non-Government applicants, excluding 18 per cent GST.

Applicants seeking shorter tenures can opt for a three-year membership, priced at ₹1.2 lakh for the Government category and ₹2.5 lakh for the non-Government category. Five-year memberships cost ₹1.8 lakh and ₹4.5 lakh, respectively, with GST charged separately.

The membership draw will determine access to the facility, which was inaugurated in 2024. Spread across 158 acres in Sector 24, Dwarka, the 18-hole championship course has a 7,377-yard layout and expansive greens.

The complex also has a 375-yard driving range with 52 bays, catering to golfers seeking practice facilities alongside access to the main course.

Its other amenities include a clubhouse, restaurant, cafeteria, snack kiosks, conference and multipurpose halls, a technology studio, a lecture hall, proshops and an equipment fitment studio.

A swimming pool and wellness centre are also part of the facility.

The DDA is developing a Golf Academy at the course as a Centre of Excellence, with the stated aim of nurturing young and aspiring golfers.

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**PUBLIC NOTICE**

THIS IS TO INFORM the general public THAT, **One Prastha Realty LLP** (PAN: AAJFO0655Q) having its registered office at Office No C-022 2nd Floor, Super Mart 1, Phase-4, Galleria DLF-IV, Gurgaon, Haryana, India, 122009 have declared that they are the owners/ developer and in possession of ALL THAT Unsold Inventory in Additional area admeasuring 6 Acres in Affordable Housing Project known as **The Elite Residences by One Prastha** (in addition to already licensed area admeasuring 52.57 Acres) comprised in Rectangle No.36, Killa No.2/1(7-8), 2/2 (0-12) 3(8-0) 8 (8-0), 9 (8-0), 12/1(2-0), 12/2(6-0),13 (7-11), 26 (0-9) total land 48 Kanal 0 Marla in village Dewru, Sector -91, Tehsil and District Sonipat, Haryana; hereinafter referred to as "**the said Property**".

It is further informed that Capri Global Capital Limited, intends to extend a financial facility to the aforesaid owner against the said Property as security and that the owners have agreed to mortgage the said Property and confirms that the said Property has clear and marketable title, without any encumbrances.

That following documents in respect of the said Property has been misplaced and are not traceable:

1. Original Sale Deed bearing no. 12788 dated 14.03.2005 executed by H P Mangla and Sons HUF in favour of Lekhchand (40/668 share) and Surajbhan, Jagat Singh, Satish Kumar, Karamsingh.
2. Original Sale Deed bearing no. 5008 dated 24.11.2003 executed by H P Mangla and Sons HUF in favour of Harjinder Singh, Rajinder Singh, Kanwaljet Singh (1/3rd share each) (19/20 share) and Jeewan Singh (1/20 share).
3. Original Sale Deed bearing no. 13286 dated 03.02.2014 executed by Lekhchand in favour of Vicky Rana.
4. CTC of Sale Deed bearing no. 267 dated 07.04.2005 executed by Harjinder Singh, Rajinder Singh, Kanwaljet Singh (19/20 share) and Jeewan Singh (1/20 share) in favour of Lekhchand (40/292 share) and Surajbhan, Jagat Singh, Satish Kumar, Karamsingh (252/292 share).
5. CTC of Sale Deed bearing no. 4209 dated 15.11.2002 executed by Meharchand, Jai Chand (2/3), Harbans Lal, Suresh Kumar, Ashok Kumar (1/3) in favour of H P Mangla and Sons HUF.
6. Original Transfer Deed bearing no. 14611 dated 05.02.2025 executed by Krishna, Suman, Savita and Kavita in favour of Sonu and Sandeep.
7. Original Transfer Deed bearing no. 14613 dated 05.02.2025 executed by Babita and Ritika in favour of Yogesh and Prince.

In case the same is found the same shall be returned to the undersigned immediately.

Any person, firm, institution or entity having objection against the proposed transaction or claiming any right, title, interest, share, claim, charge, lien, relation, encumbrances, agreement, mortgage, hypothecation, easements or any other rights, claims of any nature whatsoever over the said Property, is hereby called upon to submit their objection(s) in writing, along with supporting documentary proof, to the undersigned within 7 days from the publication of this notice. If no objection is received within the stipulated period, it shall be presumed that no person has any right or claim over the said Property, and that any such claim, if existing, has been waived. Thereafter, Capri Global Capital Limited shall proceed with the proposed financing and creation of mortgage/charge over the said property, and no subsequent objections or claims shall be entertained.

Adv. Himanshu Bansal,
Progressive Law Group,
9/14, Third Floor, East Patel Nagar,
Delhi – 110008,
himanshu@plgroup.in

DATE :- 15.10.2026

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**PUBLIC NOTICE**

Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mrs. Geeta to inform to the public at large that Mrs. Geeta is Purchasing the Built-Up Property No. RZ-9/62, Gali no. 12, Measuring 50 sq. yds., Carved Out of Khasra NO. 501, Situated at Tughlakabad Extension, New Delhi-110019 from Shri Davander Giri & Shri Ashok Giri who become the owner through Relinquishment deed dated 03.09.2021 As Doc no. 4551 SRO- V, New Delhi, Previously, this property was registered in the names of Mrs. Shakuntla Devi W/o Mr. Prabhu Giri who has purchased vide Notarized GPA & ATS dated 02.10.1987 From Land area 50 sq. yds., out of Khasra No. 501., Situated at Tughlakabad Extension, New Delhi-110019, after her death Following their demise, legal heirs, (1) Smt. Kusum Devi (2) Smt. Usha (3) Smt. Kiran Goswami (4) Mr. Davander Giri & Mr. Ashok Giri, there are no legal heirs of Shakuntla Devi except those who are mentioned and same to be finance & mortgage by **AAVAS FINANCIERS LIMITED** The Legal Heirs Certificate is Lost/Misplaced/Not available. To comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim /right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 7 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. **Lucem Legal LLP**
**N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar**
**Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre,New Delhi-110049**
**Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327**

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**Public Notice**

**This is to inform the general public that Mr. Sushil Kumar Mishra and Mr. Sandeep are the owners of Land area measuring 900 Sq. ft. out of Khasra No 120 B, Situated at Village Chipiyana Khurd alias Tigari Pargana & Tehsil Dadri Distt. Gautam Budh Nagar, U.P. They became the owners through 3 Sale Deed i.e. 1) Sale Deed dated 02.04.2025 as doc. no. 17316 executed by Mr. Krishna Gopal S/o Mr. Manohar Lal in favour of Mr. Sandeep S/o Mr. Jeet Giri and Mr. Sushil Kumar Mishra S/o Mr. Jageshwar Mishra in respect of Land area measuring 50 Sq. Yds., (i.e. 41.8 Sq. Mtrs.) out of Khasra No.120 B. 2) Sale Deed dated 05.02.2025 as doc. no. 6526 executed by Mrs. Sushma Tyagi in favour of Mr. Sandeep in respect of the area measuring 200 Sq. yds., out of khasra no. 120B, and 3) Sale Deed dated 02.04.2025 as doc. no. 17320 executed by Mr. Sandeep S/o Mr. Jeet Giri in favour of Mr. Sushil Kumar Mishra S/o Mr. Jageshwar Mishra in respect of Land area 100 Sq. Yds., (i.e. 83.61 Sq. Mtrs.) out of Khasra No. 120B.**
**Mr. Sushil Kumar Mishra and Mr. Sandeep intends to transfer the ownership of Flat no 302, 3rd Floor, area 900 Sq. ft. of above said flat by way of sale Deed to Mr. Sandeep Kumar Singh. Subsequently, Mr. Sandeep Kumar Singh is in the process of mortgaging the said flat with ICICI Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 15 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 15-days period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.**
**If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 15-days period by contacting Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301; Landline(s): +91012-04499711, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in.**

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**LOST & FOUND**

I, Puran Chand Gupta, S/o. Late Sh K.L Gupta Address 5C/55 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, New Delhi 110005 have Lost Orignal Documents of My Bawana Property Bearing Address Plot no 70, Pocket - A, Sector -2 Bawana DSIIDC, New Delhi 110039. Documents Contains Relocation, Allotment, Physical Possesion Letter, Lease Deed, COC Letter, MCD Map & Sanction Letter, Pan Card & Property Tax Receipts & other related documents of said property. Finder Please Contact Puran Chand Gupta :- 9811289990

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**PUBLIC NOTICE**

A notice of intended marriage has been received from Mr. Satvik Gurram (Mo. No.9591391587) S/o Mr. Prasad Gurram R/o H.No. 52, LIG, Bharathi Nagar, BHEL, Ramachandrapuram, Sangareddy, Telangana-502032 and Ms. Arunima Rao (Mo. No.9899298512) D/o Mr. K.V. Vijay Kumar Rao R/o 1203, Near DPS, Sector-29, Noida, Gautambudh Nagar, (U.P.) in The office of The undersigned, any person interested Therein, may file objections to it on any day upto 13-11-2026 in The office of The undersigned.

**Deputy Collector/ i/c City Magistrate/ Marriage Officer Noida Gautam Budh Nagar**

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**Office of the Executive Engineer, Construction Division, Uttarakhand Peyjal Nigam, Ramnagar, Nainital**
**(E-mail : eecdujnramnagar@gmail.com)**

**Letter No. 1332 / Vividh-16 / 31** **Date:- 12-10-2026**

**E-Tendering/Tender Notice**

Letter No./Bid No. : 1331 / Vividh-14 / 46 Dated: -12.10.2026

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Name of Work :- | (1) | Bajniyahaldu (OHT) Water Supply Scheme under Jila Yojna |
| 2 | Date of Online Publication :- 16.10.2026 at 17:00 hrs. | | |
| 3 | Class of Registration: - 'D' Category | | |
| | Details of Other Key dates, tender information etc. may be obtained at web site: **www.uktenders.gov.in** | | |

**Executive Engineer**

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**PUBLIC NOTICE**

I, SATISH KUMAR Alias S.K. Aggarwal S/O Late Shri RAM NARAIN GUPTA Registrant / Allottee of Application no. 28127 dt 26.3.1981 under Rohini Residential Scheme 1981, had submitted FDR No.08252 dated 27.3.1981 amounting to Rs.5000/- (Rupees Five Thousand only ).It is hereby informed that the aforesaid FDR has been lost / misplaced.In this regard
**1.** FIR or Non Cognizable Report NO.LR NO.717681/2026 Dated-13/10/2026 has been lodged at Police Station, Naraina,New Delhi-110028
**2.** An Indemnity Bond has also been submitted regarding loss of said FDR .If anybody has any objection/claim regarding the aforesaid FDR or finds the same, he/she may report and return to the undersigned, within 15 days of publication of this notice, To Satish Kumar Alias S K Aggarwal, D 31, Naraina Vihar, New Delhi-110028. Mobile no.8076435922.

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**यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण**
प्रथम तल, कॉमर्शियल कॉम्पलेक्स, पी–2, सैक्टर–ओमेगा–1, ग्रेटर नौएडा, जनपद गौतमबुद्धनगर–201308 (उ.प्र.)
Toll Free No. 18001808296 वेबसाइट: www.yamunaexpresswayauthority.com

पत्रांक: वाई.ई.ए./भूलेख/160/2026 दिनांक : 13.10.2026

**सार्वजनिक सूचना**

यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण ग्राम थोरा सैक्टर 8डी, ग्राम कलूपुरा के सैक्टर 5ए, व सैक्टर 05, ग्राम कुरैब सैक्टर 32, ग्राम द यौरार के अन्तर्गत आने वाली भूमि का सुनियोजित विकास हेतु सम्बन्धित कृषकों द्वारा दी गयी सहमति की दर रू0 4037/– प्रति वर्गमी0 से प्राधिकरण द्वारा शासनादेश सेख्या–314/77–3–163एम, दिनांक 23.02.2016 में तय प्रक्रियानुसार निम्नानुसार क्रय किया जाना प्रस्तावित है :–

| क्रमांक | सैक्टर/ ग्राम का नाम | काश्तकार का नाम व पता | खाता संख्या | खसरा संख्या | खसरे का कुल क्षेत्रफल (हे0 में) | काश्तकार का भाग | हिस्सानुसार क्षेत्रफल (हे0 में) | क्रय होने वाली भूमि के सापेक्ष 07 प्रतिशत क्षे0 | अन्तरिम रूप से शुद्ध देय क्षे0 (वर्ग मीटर में) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| (1) | (2) | (3) | (4) | (5) | (6) | (7) | (8) | (9) | (10) |
| 1. | सैक्टर 05 कलूपुरा | लोकेश शर्मा व राहुल शर्मा पुत्रगण चेतराम नि0 म0न0 57 सदरपुर सै0 45 नोएडा। | 292 | 930<br>931 | 0.3540<br>0.3540 | 1/4<br>1/4 | 0.0885<br>0.0885 | 123 | 120 |
| 2. | सैक्टर 5ए कलूपुरा | ललतेश देवी पत्नी प्रेम कुमार नि0 ग्राम कलूपुरा। | 36<br>304 | 984<br>985म | 1.0050<br>0.0220 | में से<br>1/5 | 0.3177<br>0.0044 | 225 | 230 |
| 3. | सैक्टर 5ए कलूपुरा | प्रदीप कुमार शर्मा पुत्र ओमदत्त शर्मा नि0 ग्राम कलूपुरा। | 320 | 360 | 1.2930 | में से | 0.2810 | 196 | 200 |
| 4. | सैक्टर 5ए कलूपुरा | मुकेश कुमार शर्मा पुत्र ओमदत्त शर्मा नि0 ग्राम कलूपुरा। | 320 | 360 | 1.2930 | में से | 0.2810 | 196 | 200 |
| 5. | सैक्टर 32 कुरैब | करम इलाही पुत्र खान मौहम्मद नि0 ग्राम नगला हाण्डा माजरा कुरैब। | 92 | 258 | 0.5370 | में से | 0.0597 | 41 | 40 |
| 6. | सैक्टर 8डी थोरा | रजनी देवी पत्नी दिनेश कुमार व प्रिया पुत्री दिनेश कुमार व प्रियान्शु पुत्र दिनेश कुमार नि0 वनीइसराइल करबा जेवर। | 277 | 1126 | 1.7110 | में से | 0.1426 | 99 | 100 |
| 7. | सैक्टर 8डी थोरा | अचला खरबंदा पुत्री अनिल खरबंदा नि0 माया एन्कलेवा हरिनगर दिल्ली। | 39<br>950 | 933<br>1127 | 0.2050<br>1.8710 | में से | 0.0410<br>0.1212 | 113 | 110 |
| 8. | सैक्टर 8डी दयौरार | अचला खरबंदा पुत्री अनिल खरबंदा नि0 माया एन्कलेवा हरिनगर दिल्ली। | 82 | 63 | 0.5930 | में से | 0.1977 | 138 | 140 |

उपरोक्त भूमि क्रय किये जाने में यदि किसी व्यक्ति को कोई आपत्ति है तो वह लिखित रूप में 15 दिन के अन्दर अधोहस्ताक्षरी को अपनी आपत्ति प्रस्तुत कर सकता है।

विशेष कार्याधिकारी
यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्यो0 वि0 प्राधिकरण।

**यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण के अधिसूचित क्षेत्र में प्राधिकरण द्वारा स्वीकृत मास्टर प्लॉन के अतिरिक्त प्लॉटिंग/हाउसिंग/कॉलोनी या किसी भी प्रकार का अन्य निर्माण पूरी तरह से अवैध है। सामान्यजन इस प्रकार की खरीदफरोख्त से पूर्णतः सचेत रहें तथा कॉलोनाइजर के भ्रामक विज्ञापनों से बचें। अधिक जानकारी के लिए प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट www.yamunaexpresswayauthority.com देखें।**

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# The Pioneer Classified

**CHANGE OF NAME**

**I, Arun S/o Rammehar R/o** Village Bashariya, Basharia (125), Baslambi, Gurugaon Haryana-122503. Here by declare that I have changed my name from Arun Sharma to Arun for all purposes. Henceforth I would be known by the name of Arun for all future purposes.

**Due to an error in my son** Shivay Sharma birth certificate, my name has been recorded as Anil Sharma, whereas my correct name is Anil Kumar Sharma. Both names refer to the same person. Anil Kumar Sharma S/o Banku Ram Sharma, R/o- RZ-3/277, Shankar Park, West Sagar Pur, Delhi- 110046.

**I, Pravin Devi, W/o JC-**472760M Sub Dinesh Kumar, R/o- Vill & PO- Birohar Dist-Jhajjar, Haryana - 124106, have changed my name from Pravin Devi to Praveen Kumari, vide affidavit dated 15/10/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

**I, Brijkishor Singh S/o** Rajindra Singh, R/o V-124, Old Nangal, Delhi Cantt, South West Delhi, New Delhi- 110010, declare that name of mine has been wrongly written as Brij Kishore Singh in my minor Daughter namely Sakshi Kumari aged 15 years in her School Records. The actual name of mine is Brijkishor Singh which may be amended accordingly.

**I, No.14642969H Hav Ashruta** Purba Roy, R/o- Vill/PO- Gobrapur, Teh- Bongaon, Dist- North 24 Parganas, West Bengal- 743251, have changed my Son's name from Ankit Roy to Ayansh Roy, vide affidavit dated 10/10/2026 before SDM Delhi Cantt.

**I, No.15734369W Lnk Ranjith** C, R/o- D No.193/2 Thatrahalli Vill & Post, Krishnagiri Taluk & Dist., Tamilnadu - 635123, have changed my son's name from R Guru Adiran to Guruadiran R, vide affidavit date 08/09/2026 before Notary Public Krishnagiri, Tamilnadu.

**I, Rekha Roy, Mother of No.** 14642969H Hav Ashruta Purba Roy, R/o- Vill/PO- Gobrapur, Teh- Bongaon, Dist- North 24 Parganas, West Bengal- 743251, have changed my name from Rekha Roy to Rekharani Roy, vide affidavit dated 10/10/2026 before SDM Delhi Cantt.

**I, N Nanthini, W/o No.** 15441712X Nk Suriyabalan B, R/o- H.No-58 East Street Oothupatti, PO-Muthulapuram, Taluk-Uthamapalayam, Dist- Theni, Tamilnadu- 625515, have changed my name from N Nanthini to Nanthini N, vide affidavit dated 15/10/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

**I, Priyanka Nisad W/o No.** 15216646L Hav Papu Kumar Nisad, R/o- Vill & PO-Pradhanpur, Teh- Rasra, Dist-Ballia, U.P.- 221712, have changed my name from Priyanka Nisad to Priyanka Chaudhari, vide affidavit dated 15/10/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

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**E-AUCTION NOTICE**
**(Fire Damaged Building Scrap, Shutter & Iron Window & Stock)**

E-Auction forms are invited from interested buyers for disposal, strictly on "As Is Where Is Basis", for salvage on Per Kg Basis, i) Fire Damaged Building Scrap, Heavy Iron, Shutter 1 No & Iron Window Approx. 5,900 Kgs. & Ii) Building Scrap Material - Sheets Approx. 1,500 Kgs & 3) Stock Pf Yarn, Bathmat, Durries, Pipe Clothing Are Burnt To Ash belonging to M/s Aarav Overseas, Chotala Road, Sewah, Near New Bus Stand, Near Sarla Textiles, Panipat, Haryana - 132103 can inspected between 16/10/26 to 22/10/26, after taking prior appointment from Mr. Nitin - 8810331841. E-Auction to be held on 23/10/26. For E-Auction forms, **Contact Ms. Khushi at Mob:- 9990857386**

**Salvor Settlers Pvt. Ltd. (Auctioneers)**
Add: 203, 2nd Floor, Usha Kiran Building, Azadpur Commercial Complex, Delhi - 110033
or download from website:
**www.salvorsettlers.com**
Last date for submission of E-Auction form is 23/10/26 before 12:30 PM

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**PUBLIC NOTICE**

Notice is hereby given to the general public that our client, Mrs. Anita Arena w/o Mr. Anil Kumar Arora, is the lawful owner and in possession of the freehold residential Entire Second floor without roof rights on Property no. A-151 area measuring 230 sq. mtrs. Situated in the layout plan of the Railway Board Employees Co-Operative House Building Society Ltd, Colony Known as Anand Vihar Delhi-110092.. Our client acquired the said property by virtue of a Sale Deed dated 18.04.2022 registered as Document No. 3441 in Book No. 01, Volume No. 3137, Pages 103-114, duly registered on 18.04.2022 in the office of the Sub-Registrar-IV-B Vivek Vihar New Delhi/Delhi. It is hereby declared that, except our client, no other person has any right, title, interest, claim, or objection whatsoever in respect of the above-mentioned property. Further, the said property has been agreed to be sold to Mr. Sachin Daga. Any person having any claim, right, title, or Interest In the aforesaid property Is hereby required to notify the same in writing, along with supporting documents, to the undersigned within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which such claims shall be deemed to have been waived.

**(NAVEEN KUMAR VERMA)**
**Advocate**
**Mo. No.: 09958871432**

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**PUBLIC NOTICE**

It is to inform to the public at large that Mrs. Valdevi had acquired Plot measuring 50 Sq. yds.+50 Sq. yrds., out of Khasra no. 538, at village Roza Jalalpur, Pargana and Tehsil Dadri, Distt. Gautma Budh Nagar, U.P. vide Sale Deed dt. 17.06.2019 and Sale Deed dt. 27.01.2025. Original Sale Deed dated 08.02.2011 executed by Mrs. Seema in favour of Mrs. Mani Devi in w.r.t said property, Doc. No. 2416 is Lost. Now Mrs. Valdevi is the undisputed owner of above said property and willing to Mortgage the above said property with CIFCL.

**OR**

Any person / firm / institution / company having any claim or right in respect of the said Property by way of inheritance, share, sale, agreement, lease, license, gift, possession, legal heirs, partners or encumbrance howsoever or otherwise is hereby required to intimate in writing to the undersigned within 07 days from the date of publication of this notice of his/her/their share or claim, if any, with all supporting documents at below mentioned address. After expiration of notice period, the claims, if any, of such person shall be treated null and void and also treated as waived and not binding on our client.

**Ajay Kumar Giri (Advocate) H No. 26/161, Basement, Vikram Vihar, Lajpat Nagar 4, New Delhi -110024**

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**PUBLIC NOTICE**

**It is hereby notified to the general public that Smt. Anjali Garg and Smt. Rina Sharma are the co-owners of the semi-built-up property bearing Property No. 117, Pocket 16, Sector-20, Rohini, Delhi.**

Any individual, person, bank, financial institution, or other entity having any claim, right, title, interest, objection, or demand of whatsoever nature in respect of the aforesaid property is hereby called upon to submit the same, in writing, along with supporting documentary evidence, to the undersigned within **15 (fifteen) days from the date of publication of this Public Notice.**

In the event no objection or claim is received within the aforesaid period, it shall be presumed that no objection has been raised in response to this notice, and any further action in respect of the said property may be proceeded with accordingly,

subject to applicable law.

**Gautam Chopra**
for Smt. Anjali Garg and Smt. Rina Sharma

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**PUBLIC NOTICE**

Notice is hereby given on behalf of **Mrs. Sukhvinder Kaur W/o Mr. Santokh Singh** who is purchasing **Property Bearing No A-77, Pertaining to Khasra No 27/15, First Floor without Roof Rights,, Gali No. 3, Village Nilothi, Uday Vihar, Nilothi Extn., New Delhi, National Capital Territory Of Delhi, New Delhi, 110041,;** from Mr. Sachin Bajaj, earlier Mr. Sachin Bajaj had purchased the same from Mr. Sumit Grover by virtue of Notarized General Power of Attorney, Agreement to sell and Will dated 28.12.2016, Now, **Mrs. Sukhvinder Kaur W/o Mr. Santokh Singh** is intend to purchase and mortgage the subject property with **VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LIMITED,** That some old property papers of the subject property i.e. **1). Original Will Dated 07.07.1989** executed by Mr. Sita Ram S/o Mr. Gopal Dass in favour of Mr. Hakam Singh S/o Mr. S. Sachu Singh and **2). Original Will Dated 17.12.1987** executed by Mr. Mahabir Singh S/o Late Mr. Tek Chand in favour of Mr. Sita Ram S/o Mr. Gopal Dass **has been misplaced/lost/not traceable,** So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/ interest/ creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within **07 days** from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. **Lucem Legal LLP**
**N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar**
**Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre,New Delhi-110049**
**Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327**

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**Public Notice**

Notice is hereby given to the general public at large that Mrs.Anu Suri W/o Mr. Rajeev Suri and Mrs.Preeti Suri W/o Mr. Sanjeev Suri are the absolute owners of Plot No.511 Sector-42, Gurugram, Haryana, admeasuring 187.20 Sq. Mts. and that they had awarded the construction work of building on the said plot to Mr. Shahid Kamal Ansari (Aadhaar No.732551218639) S/o Shakil Ahamad R/o C-23 /10A, Ground Floor, Okhla Vihar, Jamia Nagar, New Delhi-110025, in August 2025.

That the contractor has abandoned the construction work since May,2026, midway and is not traceable. The contractor has also taken advance from them which has not been adjusted.

That they have terminated the services of the contractor. Therefore, notice is hereby given that the said Mr. Shahid Kamal Ansari has no right or authority whatsoever to deal with any supplier or to enter in any contract or purchase any material on their behalf or in respect of their said plot.

Any person dealing with him in any manner with respect to their said plot shall be doing so at his/her own risk, cost and consequences. They shall not be responsible or liable for any such dealing or claim whatsoever.

For any verification, contact :-
Advocate Preeti Yadav
(Mobile No. 9911111088)

Place: Gurugram
Dated: 15/10/2026

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**L&T Finance Limited**
**Registered Office:** L&T Finance Limited, Brindavan Building Plot No. 177, Kalina, CST Road, Near Mercedes Showroom Santacruz (East), Mumbai 400 098
**CIN No.:** L67120MH2008PLC181833
**Branch office:** Gurgaon

L&T Finance

**PUBLIC NOTICE**

This is to inform the public in general and customers in particular that L&T Finance Limited (formerly known as L&T Finance Holdings Limited), having its registered office at Brindavan, Plot No. 177, C.S.T Road, Kalina, Santacruz (East), Mumbai, Maharashtra, India, 400098 shall cease to operate at its Branch Offices located at L&T Finance Limited, 1st floor SCO 392 Sec29 Near IFFCO chowk metro station Gurgaon Haryana-122015 with effect from 13-01-2027. The said closure is [on account of business requirements] and all operations of the said branch shall be shifted to L&T Finance Ltd, Unit No. 702, 703 & 704, 7th Floor, ABW Tower, IFFCO Chowk, Sector -25, Gurgaon, Haryana - 122002.

It is clarified that due care is being taken by L&T Finance Limited to ensure that no inconvenience is caused to the customers during the process of closure of the said branch(es). The accounts of all the customers shall be transferred to the transferee branch referred above and all such customers shall be serviced from that branch from the effective date. Customers are hereby requested to take note of the aforesaid change. In case of further clarification and/or in case of any difficulty, customers may contact 98997-34567.

Sd/-
**Authorized Officer**
For L&T FINANCE LIMITED

**Date:** 16.10.2026
**Place:** Gurgaon

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The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | OCTOBER 16, 2026



# Centre, police apologise to SC but justify October 10 curbs over CJP protest

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Apologising to the top court over alleged violation of the apex court's direction to ensure no "complete prohibition" on Metro and train services in Delhi, the Government on Thursday justified the restrictions imposed on October 10 in parts of the Capital in the wake of a protest call by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP).

Offering an unconditional apology, Union Home Secretary Govind Mohan and Delhi Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar justified their decisions to suspend mobile internet services in parts of central Delhi and deny permission to hold a protest at Jantar Mantar on October 10.

The Commissioner of Police told the court that timely, proportionate, and lawful police measures helped avert a major public order situation during the recent protests in the national capital.

The commissioner further stated that preventive measures were based on intelligence inputs and an assessment of the prevailing and ever-changing ground situation. In an affidavit filed before the Supreme Court, Mohan Mohan denied that the Centre wilfully disobeyed the court's directions, saying Delhi Police requested a one-day suspension of cellular internet services until 10 pm on October 10.

"The request was duly processed and considered in accordance with law and was found to be a proportionate measure, having regard to the magnitude of the situation and the need to prevent any disturbance of public order in the national capital," Mohan said. The home secretary said cellular internet services were suspended from 10 pm on October 9 to 10 pm on October 10 within a 4 km radius of Raisina Hill.

He clarified that the suspension applied only to cellular internet services and did not extend to non-cellular internet services or telecommunication services such as Wi-Fi or broadband.

"I state and submit that the suspension of internet services for a limited period and within a defined geographical area, subject to the applicable statutory safeguards, is a recognised measure that may be considered for maintaining public order in appropriate circumstances," he said.

"I therefore respectfully pray that this court may be pleased to modify its order dated October 11 to the extent necessary to permit the suspension of internet services



in situations of necessity, strictly in accordance with law and subject to the applicable statutory requirements and safeguards," he said.

In an affidavit, the Delhi Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar stated that the permission for the October 10 CJP protest at Jantar Mantar was denied due to experience of large-scale violence during its July 20 protests, inability of organisers to control supporters and the grave inconvenience caused to the general public because of a string of protests from October 6-8 that choked central Delhi for days together.

The commissioner said Narrating the sensitivity of central Delhi housing Rashtrapati Bhavan, Parliament, Supreme Court, embassies and other institutions requiring a complex security arrangement as well as measures for maintaining public order, the police commissioner said, "No police administration can permit any breach of public order in the national capital, particularly when a call is given by an organisation with a recent history of mob violence, and incidents resulting in injuries to several individuals and the subsequent events of October 6, 7, 8."

Due to all these marches, the central Delhi areas got completely choked, and there were huge traffic snarls for long hours, resulting in students and innocent citizens getting stuck in traffic jams, resulting in them missing their trains, airlines, etc.," he said.

The gatherings were very aggressive, fuelled by persons adopting the cover of 'freelance journalism', who were physically harassing policemen; some miscreants were misbehaving with lady police personnel, resulting in injuries to over a dozen police personnel," he said on the October 10 protest which was called despite denial of permission and attempts to gather people illegally.

As per the SC-laid-down law, the Police removed the illegally gathered people from the site where prohibitory orders were in place. Still, those detained punctured the tyres of the buses in which they were kept and broke window shields in acts of violence, the commissioner said.

# HC lets CJP protest at Central Park, takes police assurance on record

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Thursday refused to restrain the CJP and its founder, Abhijeet Dipke, from holding a protest at Connaught Place's Central Park on October 16, even as it took on record the police's assurance that it would take all possible steps to regulate and control the protesters' activity.

A bench of Acting Chief Justice Nitin Wasudeo Sambre and Justice Sanjay Sharma heard a plea by a Connaught Place vendor seeking directions to the police to regulate the protest under existing law laid down by the Supreme Court.

The petitioner's senior counsel submitted that traders and vendors would be "on the streets" if they lost another weekend to closures due to protests in central Delhi during the festive season.

Dipke on Wednesday called on "patriots" to gather at Central Park on October 16 with the national flag, alleging that CJP members Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka were "jailed for unfurling the tricolour". The call came on a day Das and Ranka were sent to five-day judicial custody and were lodged in Tihar Jail for allegedly violating their peace bonds and trespassing into Jantar Mantar, which has been denotified as a protest area.

During the hearing on Thursday, Additional Solicitor General (ASG) Chetan Sharma submitted that steps have been taken to control the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP)'s activities and assured the court that the petitioner's apprehension would be



addressed. The court took the assurance on record.

"The petitioner apprehends that the conduct of respondent no. 6 (CJP) is likely to disrupt business activity in Connaught Place... When confronted, the ASG assured that the petitioner's apprehension would be addressed, as the respondents had already taken steps to control and regulate the activity of respondent no. 6 and, if required, would take all possible steps in accordance with law. The assurance is taken on record," the order said, while listing it for further hearing on November 3.

Even as the senior counsel for the petitioner urged the court to pass a "specific" direction restraining the CJP, the bench said, "Don't insist. We have passed the order."

Senior advocate Sachhin Puri, appearing for a licensed street vendor selling ready-made garments at Palika Bazar, argued that Connaught Place was not a designated protest site and that any agitation in the central park there would affect their business.

The court observed that the authorities had already denotified Jantar Mantar as a designated protest site and asked why the petitioner apprehended that the police would not take necessary action regarding the proposed protest. The ASG responded that the police would "perform its duty".

The petition, filed as a PIL by Anil Kumar Gupta, said that until its de-notification, the conditions governing protests at Jantar Mantar were not enforced, which led to vendors losing business.

"On or about 20.07.2026, a large agitation spilt beyond the designated area. The roads around Jantar Mantar and Parliament Street were barricaded and came to a standstill. Customers stopped coming to Connaught Place and Palika Bazar, and the petitioner could not vend, which caused daily loss," the plea stated. The bench agreed to hear the petition urgently earlier in the day.

"In the heart of Connaught Place Central Park, a protest is called. It seems we are being targeted. This is not a site (for protest). They have already started shutting down. This is the Dussehra weekend. This protest has to be stopped," the petitioner's senior counsel had said while mentioning the matter in the morning.

# Multi-layer security planned around CP amid protest

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Delhi Police have outlined a multi-layered deployment around Connaught Place's Central Park to manage the CJP protest scheduled for Friday. The arrangement is designed to contain the gathering, protect normal commercial and pedestrian movement, and respond quickly to any potential disturbance.



At the outermost level, traffic and local police units will control access roads leading into Connaught Place. Temporary diversions and intermittent checks will be put in place on major approach roads to prevent sudden surges of vehicles or additional crowds from entering the core area.

Officers will regulate the flow of public transport and private vehicles so that essential movement continues without prolonged blockages. Closer to Central Park, an intermediate cordon of barricades and personnel will mark the boundary of the designated protest zone.

This layer will channel protesters toward the approved assembly area while keeping shoppers, office workers and visitors on separate pathways. Additional personnel will be stationed at key intersections and entry points to the market complex to stop any spillover into busy shopping corridors or metro access points.

Inside the immediate vicinity of Central Park, a denser deployment of officers will supervise the assembly itself. These units will monitor crowd size, ensure the gathering remains within the allocated space, and intervene if the protest moves beyond permitted limits.

A quick-reaction team will remain on standby nearby, ready to reinforce any point where tension or obstruction arises. Continuous communication between ground units and the control room will allow rapid redeployment if conditions change.

The force has also factored in surveillance and coordination. CCTV feeds from the Connaught Place area will be monitored in real time, and liaison will be maintained with metro and fire services for contingency support.

The overall plan rests on the Delhi High Court's assurance that it will take every feasible step to regulate and control the protesters under existing legal guidelines.

The multi-layered setup aims to keep the Friday demonstration orderly while limiting disruption in one of the capital's busiest commercial centres.

# CJP-AISA press conference descends into chaos before march




CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke, advocate Prashant Bhushan, actor Prakash Raj, AISA President Neha Bora, and others during a press conference at the Press Club of India in New Delhi on Thursday PANKAJ KUMAR

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Chaos erupted at Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke and AISA chief Neha Bora's joint press conference on Thursday, a day ahead of CJP's '*Lehra do Tiranga* ' protest march. People at the presser were heard saying: "Band karo...dafa ho jaao" (Stop it; get lost) before Bora urged the management to escort the disruptors out. The CJP has announced a "Lehra do Tiranga" march at Central Park in Connaught Place on Friday. Dipke urged citizens to join the demonstration, saying waving the national flag is a democratic right. He also appealed to political parties to join.

Addressing a press conference along with All India Students' Association national president Neha Bora, Students' Federation of India leader Aishe Ghosh, All India Students' Federation national president Viraaj Devang and actor Prakash Raj among others, Dipke alleged that students and young people had been protesting in Delhi for the past 10-15 days and were being dragged away by authorities.

On the crackdown on protesters, Dipke said, "Former chief ministers Mamata Banerjee, Arvind Kejriwal, Pinarayi Vijayan, MPs, leaders of the opposition, all were detained. For the first time in the history of India, the Railways was shut, and metros were shut for Gyanesh," he said, questioning why the Government was protecting the chief election commissioner. Describing the slogan of 'One Nation, One Election' as a cover for a different political objective, he said, "One Nation, One Election' was a slogan. The real intention is One Nation, One Party, One Leader."

He accused the Government of trying to influence electoral outcomes through alleged voter deletions and asked whether striking off the names of over 13 crore voters was a "setting".Questioning the deletions against the backdrop of the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, he said, "The margin of victory in 2024 was just 2 per cent. Over 13 crore voters deleted." "Where 2 per cent is deciding the election, you are deleting 13 crore votes. What is this if not a setting," he asked.

"(Narendra) Modi cannot be bigger than (Mahatma) Gandhi and (Jawaharlal) Nehru," he added. Bora alleged that the police had targeted journalists covering the protests, detaining them despite their press credentials and snatching their cameras. She also referred to an alleged sexual harassment incident involving a journalist, in which an FIR was registered. She accused the police of using force against people raising concerns over electoral rights. "Police, instead of maintaining law and order, crack down on the public. This is a classic example of what we have seen," she said.

# Police urge public to avoid CJP's Tiranga march, offer limited symbolic display

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Delhi Police has urged people to stay away from the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) proposed '*Lehra Do Tiranga*' march at Connaught Place on Friday, but said it could facilitate a select group of people to wave the national flag and sing the national anthem at a suitable place.

In a statement issued on Thursday, police cited prohibitory orders in force in Connaught Place and adjoining areas, while indicating that a limited number of people could be allowed to participate in the symbolic display of patriotism.

Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) is already in force in the area to maintain peace and tranquillity and protect human lives as well




as public and private properties, the statement said.

Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke on Thursday urged people to join the "*Lehra do Tiranga*" march carrying the national flag at Central Park, Connaught Place, on Friday amid a stand-off with Delhi Police over demonstrations against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar.

The CJP has appealed to the public through social media and a press conference to assemble at Central Park at 5 pm on October 16 with tricolour flags.

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) has informed Delhi Police that Central Park will remain closed on October 16 and 17 for administrative reasons. It has also requested adequate security arrangements to prevent unauthorised access to the park, the statement said.

Police said various trader and market associations in Connaught Place and adjoining areas had sought protection for their establishments from unruly elements and unlawful assemblies, which could adversely affect business during the festive season.

Cautioning against violations of Section 163 BNSS, police said they would take legal action against those who defy the prohibitory orders and appealed to the public to help maintain peace and tranquillity.

It also emphasised that the national flag must be carried and displayed, and the national anthem sung, in the prescribed manner and with due respect, dignity and decorum.

# Tax revenue rises 3.5% to ₹27,030 cr in first half of FY26

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Delhi Government earned ₹2,030.38 crore in tax revenue in the first half of the current financial year, 3.5 per cent more than the same period last fiscal year, officials said on Thursday.

The total tax revenue of the Government stood at ₹32,547.70 crore as on October 9 this year, according to the official data.

The excise tax revenue in the first two quarters of the ongoing financial year stood at ₹3,152.85 crore, up 6 per cent against ₹2,947.53 crore recorded in the same period of 2025-26, the data showed.

The total tax revenue was ₹26,128.48 crore up to September 2025. In the current year, it stood at ₹27,030.38 crore up to September. The Delhi Government has estimated total tax collection of ₹74,000 crore in 2026-27.

"Streamlined policies and targeted action have helped improve the tax collections. The collections were higher




as compared to the first half of last year in almost all categories, including VAT, stamps and registration, and motor vehicles tax, among others," said a senior Delhi Government officer.

The biggest contributor to Delhi's tax revenue in the first half of this year was the Goods and Services Tax (GST) with ₹19,023.42 crore, which was higher than ₹18,710.89 crore in the same period of the preceding fiscal year.

Other major collections up to September this year were stamps and registration fee at ₹4,482.50 crore, value added tax (VAT) at ₹3,826.43 crore, excise ₹3,152.85 crore, and motor vehicle tax ₹1,613.76 crore.

# Cockroach effigy to join Ravan's army at Ramlila

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

In a city where a cockroach has become an unlikely symbol of political dissent, the insect is set to find another, rather different role this Dussehra: a 30-foot effigy that will go up in flames alongside Ravan, Kumbhkaran and Meghnad at a Ramlila in Pitampura.

The Shree Keshav Ram Leela Committee, which organises the annual event in northwest Delhi, says the cockroach represents filth and dirt. Its burning, the committee maintains, is intended to reinforce the message of cleanliness and the triumph of good over evil, as part of the Swachh Bharat and Swachh Delhi campaigns. But the announcement arrives at a politically charged moment for the capital, with the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) leading protests against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar over alleged irregularities in the revision of electoral rolls.

Ashok Goel, the committee's president and a BJP MLA, has denied that the decision to include the insect in the effigy-burning ceremony has any political motivation. He said the cockroach would also feature among the demons in Ravan's army. The symbolism, however, is difficult to separate from the political moment.



The CJP, whose name turns the familiar household pest into a political identity, has returned to Delhi's streets after an earlier agitation over alleged irregularities in competitive examinations.

The group staged a protest at Jantar Mantar through June and July and marched towards Parliament on July 20. Its campaign targeted then Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the examination controversy. Pradhan subsequently resigned, although the protest alone does not establish the circumstances behind his departure. The CJP has since shifted its focus to the Election Commission. It has demanded Kumar's resignation over alleged irregularities in the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, drawing support from opposition parties and student organisations.

The demonstrations have also brought confrontations with the police. Several activists, students and journalists were detained during the recent protests, while restrictions around central Delhi disrupted public movement.

The dispute has continued beyond the streets. On Thursday, the Delhi High Court declined to stop a CJP gathering planned at Connaught Place's Central Park for October 16. The court recorded the Delhi Police's assurance that it would take lawful steps to regulate the event. The proposed gathering follows the detention of CJP activists Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka in connection with a protest at Jantar Mantar.

The legal challenge had been brought by a Palika Bazar vendor who argued that demonstrations and associated traffic restrictions could hurt access to the market and affect the livelihoods of small traders. The court's decision leaves the planned gathering to proceed subject to police regulation.

Against this backdrop, the Pitampura committee's explanation is straightforward: the effigy is about sanitation, not the CJP.

The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | OCTOBER 16, 2026



# Big items done in US-India trade deal: Sergio

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor on Thursday said negotiations for a bilateral trade deal were moving at an "incredible pace", and the "big items are done", underlining that he was confident that both sides will get the pact through.

During an interactive session at the Bloomberg New Economy Forum here, Gor also echoed External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar's assessment of the progress in the proposed India-US trade pact, saying "we are very close to landing it".

Asked about the status of the negotiations, Gor said, "I won't like to get into too many details at this stage, and let the ministers announce that. But in the grand scheme of things, big items are done."


US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor

"We're actively engaged... Within three weeks of arriving here, we announced a trade deal. The European Union trade deal took almost 20 years. So we're at an incredible pace, and I am confident that we will get it done," Gor said.

The India-EU Free Trade Agreement (FTA) was successfully concluded in January after nearly 20 years of negotiation. Later, in a post on X, Gor said, "The US-India partnership has come a long way, but the most important chapter is still ahead. At the @BBGNewEconomy Forum, I spoke about the enormous potential of the US-India partnership, and why now is the time to turn commitments into real results!"

India has maintained that both sides remain engaged for a mutually beneficial bilateral trade agreement.

During the interaction, Gor said, "We have been at it for a year-and-a-half. We are at an incredible pace, I would say almost an unheard of pace... So I am confident that we will get it (the deal) done."

The two sides continue to engage to iron out differences on the proposed deal, and negotiations are heading towards a "landing point", Jaishankar had said at an earlier session at the Forum, noting that the core fundamentals of the bilateral strategic partnership remained unchanged.

Gor said, "We are getting there. I am confident that we will have a trade deal here, as you heard Dr Jaishankar say right on this stage, and we are very close to landing it."

He was also asked about the Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026, and if there is any room for some sanctions relief or exemptions related to it for India."That is a decision for the president," Gor said, adding the legislation gives the US president that authority.

He has not imposed sanctions on any country yet. The bill was passed recently, and "he has to make a determination within the next 10 days or so, and I am sure we will see an announcement from the White House soon," Gor said.

On September 18, US President Donald Trump signed into law the 'Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026', which authorises him to impose tariffs of up to 100 per cent on countries buying Russian oil and gas, including China and India. Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri, during his meeting with a bipartisan US Congressional delegation in Delhi, had conveyed India's "concerns" over the implications of the recently enacted Act on bilateral ties and the international energy market.

# 250 idol collection kiosks to come up across Delhi



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Delhi residents will soon have designated kiosks to deposit damaged idols and worship materials instead of dumping them in parks, streets or water bodies, with the Municipal Corporation of Delhi signing an agreement with Plastindia Foundation to set up 250 such collection centres across MCD wards in the first phase. Of these, 60 kiosks have already been installed at designated locations, Plastindia Foundation Chairman Alok Tibrewala said, adding that the foundation had developed, supplied and installed the centres free of cost as part of its commitment to environmental protection and responsible waste management.

The Memorandum of Understanding was signed on the initiative of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, with the agreement formalised at a programme held at the Delhi Secretariat on Thursday. The event was attended by Delhi Mayor Pravesh Wahi, Standing Committee Chairperson Satya Sharma, Leader of the House Jaibhagwan Yadav, Municipal Commissioner Sanjeev Khirwar and officials from concerned departments.

Under the initiative, residents will be able to deposit damaged idols and related religious materials at the kiosks after performing rituals, instead of leaving them in open spaces or immersing them in water bodies. The collected materials will then be segregated and recycled through a proper management process.

The Chief Minister said the initiative was aimed at ensuring that citizens could continue their religious practices while also fulfilling their responsibility toward keeping the city clean. She appealed to residents to use the designated centres rather than leaving idols and worship materials on roads, in open spaces or in water bodies, saying even small individual efforts could meaningfully improve cleanliness and environmental protection across the city.

## Ankita murder: UKD, Congress protest outside governor house



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Dehradun

The Congress in Uttarakhand on Thursday staged a protest outside the Lok Bhawan here demanding that the appointment of Dushyant Kumar Gautam as Sikkim governor be put on hold till the probe into the Ankita Bhandari murder case is complete. Several senior leaders including former chief minister Harish Rawat were among 50 odd people to be detained.

State unit chief Ganesh Godiyal, former minister Harak Singh Rawat and MLA Pritam Singh were also detained.

The Uttarakhand Congress began its protests a day after Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday met Ankita's parents, who were protesting at India Gate demanding justice for their daughter, and expressed solidarity with them.

# EC orders special summary revision of voters list in 17 States

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi




Election Commission of India (ECI) on Thursday ordered holding the annual special summary revision (SSR) of electoral rolls in 17 States and Union territories, including those where assembly polls are due "early next year".

The final rolls in these states and Union territories will be published on January 4. A senior EC functionary explained that SSR is an annual exercise mandates under election law. It is specially held in poll-bound States. In these 17 States, special intensive revision of voters' list has been completed. In Assam, a special revision instead of SIR had taken place due to legal reasons.

For the first time, parties will be shared "readable" electoral rolls at draft and final stages in both hard and soft versions. Candidates in poll-bound states will also be shared draft and final rolls. Rolls will also be made available for sale by the ERO to other persons before the elections. To ensure inclusion of youth, those turning 18 on or before January 1 next, will be encouraged to fill enrollment forms. This will help them become voters ahead of polls in Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Goa, Manipur and Punjab. The EC told its poll officials that polls in these states are due "early next year". In its letters to chief electoral officers of these states, the poll authority said January 1, 2027 will be the qualifying date.

The poll roll revision aims to enrol eligible voters, particularly young and first-time electors, correct electoral roll entries and improve the purity of voter lists.

In SSR, there will be no house to house visits by BLOs to electors as SIR has already taken place and electors have more or less been identified. The states where SSR will be held are: Andaman and Nicobar Island, Assam, Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Goa, Gujarat, Kerala, Lakshadweep, Madhya Pradesh, Manipur, Puducherry, Punjab, Rajasthan, Tamil Nadu, Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, and West Bengal.

While the term of the 403-member UP assembly ends on May 22 next year, the terms of 60-member Manipur, 40-member Goa, 117-member Punjab and 70-member Uttarakhand assembly end on different dates in March, 2027.

Provisions of The Representation of the People Act, 1950 allows EC to hold polls "earlier than six months before the term expires".

# Anti-drug activist murder sparks Punjab bandh: Markets shut, roads blocked in protest

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Hoshiarpur/Ludhiana

A State-wide 'bandh' call on Thursday over the murder of anti-drug activist Parvinder Singh Jhota in Mansa evoked a strong response in Punjab, with markets and educational institutions remaining shut and protesters blocking roads at several places, disrupting traffic movement.

Jhota's family had given the 'Punjab Bandh' call from 6 am till 5 pm with support from the Congress, Akali Dal, BJP and Akali Dal Waris Punjab De, the Samyukta Kisan Morcha and other farmer unions, and state government employee bodies. Known for raising his voice against drug abuse and illegal sale of addictive substances at chemist shops, Jhota was shot in broad daylight inside a medical store at a busy marketplace in Mansa on Tuesday.

Ashwani Kumar, the store owner who opened fire on Jhota after he questioned him for selling addictive drugs to an elderly man, was taken into custody from Salasar in Rajasthan. The incident, which took place while Jhota was hosting a Facebook Live, triggered a political slugfest in Punjab, which goes to polls early next year. While Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann has vowed the strictest punishment for those behind the killing, opposition leaders have claimed a complete breakdown of law and order amid a "jungle raj" in the State.

Jhota's father Bhim Singh, an ex-serviceman, had urged everyone to support the bandh call. A joint action committee comprising various organisations and social activists formed after Jhota's murder has demanded the resignations of Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann and DGP Gaurav Yadav and the dismissal of the Mansa SSP, DSP, SHO and the drug inspector. They are also demanding a CBI probe into the matter.


Protesters chant slogans from a top a vehicle as they block traffic during a 'Punjab Bandh' protest following the killing of anti-drug activist Parvinder Singh Jhota in Amritsar on Thursday PTI

The family has refused to perform the last rites of Jhota, whose body is lying at the mortuary of the civil hospital in Mansa, until justice is delivered. In response to the bandh call, shops and markets remained shut at several places on Thursday, including Hoshiarpur, Amritsar, Ferozepur, Ludhiana, Jalandhar, Sangrur, Barnala, Moga, Patiala and Mansa. However, emergency services remained operational.

Several toll plazas, including in Ludhiana and Patiala, did not charge any fee from the commuters in support of the bandh call. Many private schools in Hoshiarpur, Jalandhar, Moga and Mansa declared a holiday in view of the shutdown.

Protesters blocked several roads, including national highways, at multiple locations, prompting authorities to divert traffic through alternative routes.

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## BR Shetty sues BoB for $15 Billion

The number of this judgment was quoted by the BoB to the Stock Exchanges without explaining why it paid ₹5,700 crore in public money as a settlement and not challenged in higher courts. Bank of Baroda was represented by noted lawyer Harish Salve.

Now, two days ago, Shetty filed law suit against BoB in Mumbai High Court demanding 15 billion dollars (₹1.44 lakh crores) for the collapse of empire NMC Healthcare. Shetty has sought $5 billion in direct damages, $5 billion for consequential losses, including lost business opportunities, and another $5 billion for reputational damage. The first two claims are against all defendants, while the reputational damages claim is against Bank of Baroda alone. He has also sought 18% annual interest on the amounts claimed.

The suit names 26 defendants, including the bank, 10 of its officials, former NMC executives Prasanth Manghat and Promoth Manghat, their associates, and two Indian companies, Avitis Super Speciality Hospitals Pvt Ltd and SMARD Building Solutions Pvt. Ltd. Shetty accuses the bank of processing suspicious transactions, ignoring repeated anti-money laundering alerts and allowing transfers based on signatures and instructions he claims were forged or unauthorised. The allegations have not been established in court.

Shetty alleged that the bank's Abu Dhabi branch "advised the Manghat team how to structure and paper those transactions so that they would pass scrutiny". It also accused the bank of executing "every leg of the round tripping" of funds from NMC. Shetty accused that about AED42 million was allegedly paid to Prasanth Manghat between May 2018 and January 2019 through an account linked to Guide General Contracting and Maintenance. Shetty questions the purpose of these payments and alleges that the bank failed to address compliance concerns.

Shetty claimed that he often signed large numbers of documents presented by people he trusted, sometimes signing between 100 and 200 documents a day. He alleges that some signatures were obtained by misleading him, while others were copied electronically or forged. He also alleges that two accounts were opened in his name at the National Bank of Fujairah in December 2017 and March 2019 without his knowledge. The documents used to open the accounts allegedly carried forged signatures and authorizations. He claimed that the accounts were later used to move money from group companies to the Manghat brothers, their associates and companies they controlled.

Citing series of charges, Shetty alleged that Bank of Baroda accepted instructions on his personal account from people who were not authorized to operate it, even though Joseph Pinto was the only authorized signatory. He claims the bank also honoured cheques bearing forged signatures.

## Nobody can browbeat judiciary: CJI

The court directed that the court's CCTV recordings from the INDIA bloc's protest be preserved.

The bench issued notice to the poll panel, Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar, and Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, seeking their responses to the plea filed by Gandhi and others.

During the hearing in a packed courtroom, the moment Rahul Gandhi's plea was called out, senior advocate Abhishek Singhvi commenced the submissions, saying the case pertains to the issue of collective decision-making by the poll panel and the alterations made in Form 6. Form 6 is an application through which an eligible person seeks inclusion in the electoral roll. Simultaneously, senior advocate Kapil Sibal told the bench that he was appearing in the case for Rahul Gandhi. This led Solicitor General Tushar Mehta to ask who was representing Gandhi in the case.

Besides the plea filed by Rahul Gandhi and others, the apex court also dealt with petitions concerning protests, including alleged assault on journalists and lawyers, and SIR. The top court also issued notices to Rahul Gandhi, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav, TMC MP Mahua Moitra and the Congress party on a plea against the October 12 march to the top court. The bench also issued notices to the poll panel and others on a plea filed by AIMIM chief Asaduddin Owaisi seeking to set aside the SIR.

The bench also told the Centre that it was not taking cognisance of media reports suggesting that government authorities tendered unconditional apologies in contempt proceedings over alleged violations of its directions concerning Metro and train services in Delhi during a protest against SIR on October 10.

This comes after Solicitor General Tushar Mehta pointed out that media headlines and social media posts portrayed the affidavits as admissions of wrongdoing, without considering the explanations and justifications the authorities provided. According to drafting norms, the affidavits filed by the Union Home Secretary, DMRC and Delhi Police start with the averments that unconditional apologies are tendered, the top law officer said. The CJI responded that media coverage was not relevant to the court's proceedings. "What the media does is not relevant. We are not holding proceedings for the media," the CJI said. Justice Bagchi then said the court was not taking cognisance of the unqualified apology referred to by the Solicitor General, adding that, in view of Mehta's submissions, the apology appeared to be qualified.

The top court also sought responses from the Centre and the Delhi Police on a separate plea challenging the de-notification of Jantar Mantar as a designated protest site in the national capital. Among other issues, the bench dealt with the matter relating to a woman journalist, whose complaint alleging molestation by a senior police officer is pending consideration. The bench directed the police not to take any coercive action against the journalist.

When this plea was entertained, Bhatia urged the bench also to consider the case of a pregnant woman journalist, who, he said, was allegedly pushed by Gandhi in the apex court premises during the October 12 march. The bench asked him to file a petition on the matter and said it would consider the issue. "Before this court, every voice is valuable, and everyone will be heard irrespective of numbers," the bench said. On the plea filed by Rahul Gandhi and others, the bench issued notice to the poll panel, Chief Election Commissioner Kumar and the two election commissioners.

The top court sought responses from the Centre and others on a plea seeking guidelines governing how police and law-enforcement authorities interact with journalists during protests and crowd-control operations. The bench directed that no coercive action be taken against a woman journalist, against whom a case has been filed by a Delhi Police officer alleging casteist remarks and public humiliation against him during a protest near Jantar Mantar here.

The bench also sought responses from the Centre and others on a plea seeking a direction that those who organise or call for protests be held responsible for loss of life, injury, and damage to public or private property.

## CJP's Tricolour march faces police curbs

Police did leave a small opening. They said a select group could wave the national flag and sing the national anthem at a suitable place. Only a limited number would be allowed. Police added that the flag must be carried and the anthem sung in the prescribed manner, with respect, dignity and decorum.

For traders, the stakes are about business. Police said market and trader associations in Connaught Place and nearby areas had sought protection for their establishments from unruly elements and unlawful assemblies. They fear trouble could hurt sales during the festive season.

Heavy security has been put in place in and around Connaught Place and Jantar Mantar. Several paramilitary units are already in the capital. Police officials said they will place personnel at strategic locations. Barricades will go up, and the movement of protesters and commuters will be regulated to prevent any untoward incident. For those travelling through the area, that could mean checks and delays.

A senior police officer said Connaught Place is not a designated protest site. He said Jantar Mantar has been denotified as a protest site. Protesters can hold demonstrations at Ramlila Maidan, Burari Ground or CBD Ground after obtaining the requisite permission, an official said.

The stand-off has been building through the week. Delhi Police denotified Jantar Mantar's status as a designated protest site earlier this week. The CJP responded by returning to the venue with the national flag.

On Wednesday, CJP leaders Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka were sent to five days of judicial custody. They were arrested after entering Jantar Mantar and raising slogans demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar. The party then announced the march at Central Park.

Addressing a press conference on Thursday, CJP founder Abhijit Dipke appealed to people to join the march carrying the national flag. He also made a wider call. "I request all political parties and civil society groups to rise above ideology and come together. If the right to vote is not saved, democracy will not be saved," Dipke said.

The party has spread its appeal through social media and the press conference. Whether the crowd gathers is now uncertain. With the park gates closed and prohibitory orders in place, the venue the party chose will not be open to the public on the day it asked them to come.

## SC draws line on caste quotas after conversion

The top court further held that a person who professes a religion other than Hinduism, Sikhism, or Buddhism cannot be believed to be a member of a scheduled caste. "Consequently, upon conversion to a religion not specified therein, such person ceases to possess the scheduled caste status attached to his antecedent caste and cannot claim any affirmative action benefit of a backward class under Article 16(4) of the Constitution, which is predicated upon membership of a scheduled caste status," it said. It said that conversion to a non-Hindu social order does not by itself confer membership of any particular notified backward class community.

"A person's pre-conversion caste or community status cannot, merely by reason of conversion, be transposed into membership of a distinct notified backward class community in the post-conversion social order," it said, adding that social backwardness, which forms the basis of the person's pre-conversion status, cannot by itself be the only legal foundation for conferring upon a membership of a different notified backward class community after conversion.

Conversely, where a person converts from the Hindu social order to a non-Hindu social order and then reconverts to the the Hindu social order, the question of his entitlement to affirmative action under Article 16(4) cannot be determined merely by reference to his antecedent status. "Such entitlement would require an independent fact-specific determination by the competent authority as to whether the original caste or social identity has genuinely revived upon reconversion, and whether the person satisfies the applicable constitutional and legal requirements for such affirmative action," it held.

It concluded, "We, therefore, affirm the conclusion of the High Court, though our reasoning focuses on the constitutional foundation set out above. A person who converts to Islam does not, by that act alone, become a member of any one of the seven notified backwards-class communities in the state. These former caste or community patterns cannot automatically be transposed into the Muslim backward-class category, nor can a private religious body conclusively determine such statutory entitlement."

On August 7, the top court reserved its decision on the plea the state government filed against the high court verdict. The state government had contended that the object behind its order of March 9, 2024 was to ensure that persons belonging to socially and educationally backward communities are not deprived of reservation benefits solely on account of conversion to Islam. The HC's verdict came on a petition filed by one Sameer Ahamed, who converted from Hinduism to Islam in 2015, with the conversion being notified through a Gazette notification in 2016.

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# Ladakh youth to get quality education, new technologies: PM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Jammu

Emphasising that Ladakh's development is a top Centre priority, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Thursday that the Union Territory's youth are receiving special attention for quality education and new technologies. As a result, they no longer need to leave for other cities.

Virtually inaugurating five major projects worth around ₹3,350 crore, covering airport infrastructure and strategic road connectivity, he stressed that the Government will build modern infrastructure while fully protecting the local environment.

Prioritising the younger generation's educational empowerment, Modi highlighted plans the build a major centre of excellence in Leh and advanced proposals for satellite campuses of IIT Jammu and IIM Jammu.

These premier institutions will equip local students with advanced research and modern technological skills right at their doorstep, Modi said. "Our special focus is on the new generation of Ladakh. The youth of Ladakh will now be able to get better opportunities for higher education, research, and new skills right in their own region," he said.

The prime minister also said that Ladakh is adding another chapter to its progress and development today, and he was happy to be part of the occasion virtually. "Several important development projects have been inaugurated today. These projects will make travel easier for many people in Ladakh, improve electricity facilities in some areas, increase water availability in others, and strengthen the preservation of our ancient heritage," he said.

Hailing the Centre's initiatives, Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena said the region has seen a major transformation in infrastructure and living standards under the Prime Minister's leadership since it became a Union Territory in 2019.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi during the launch of multiple development projects for Ladakh via video conferencing PTI

Saxena said, "Five new infrastructure projects would prove to be milestones in Ladakh's development, strengthening connectivity, water security, power supply and preservation of cultural heritage." The Lieutenant Governor (LG) thanked Narendra Modi for his leadership and support, saying the people of Ladakh's seven districts looked forward to his address with high hopes and aspirations.The projects include a new passenger terminal at the Kushok Bakula Rimpochee Airport in Leh, built for ₹640 crore.

Recalling his earlier laying of the foundation stone for the Kushok Bakula Rimpochee Airport terminal in Leh, the Prime Minister expressed delight at inaugurating the facility, which triples flight capacity and expands annual passenger handling from 10 lakh to 35 lakh.

He highlighted that the terminal is India's first to feature geothermal heating alongside solar energy usage to suit the harsh climate, energising local tourism while balancing infrastructure growth with ecological care. "Our effort is to develop modern infrastructure in Ladakh while taking full care of the local environment," asserted the PM. Underscoring the strategic and economic value of regional connectivity, the Prime Minister also dedicated the 2,500-crore-rupee Nimmu-Padum-Darcha road to the citizens, noting that it slashes travel time from 12 hours down to just 3 hours.

He emphasised that beyond saving commuters' time, this vital corridor will significantly boost local commerce. "This road will also greatly help trade and business," noted PM Modi.

Modi also dedicated a 9 MW Hanu small hydroelectric project and the 66 kV double-circuit Dah-Hanu-Khaltsi transmission line to the nation.

In addition, the prime minister inaugurated India's first Petroglyph Conservation Park at Sindhu Ghat in Leh and 40 water bodies developed across 40 villages under Project Him Sarovar.

"I extend my heartiest congratulations to all the people of Ladakh for these projects. I also congratulate all the engineers, workers and local colleagues involved in these projects. I specially appreciate the colleagues of the BRO," he said.

Modi said Ladakh has immense sports potential, and the youth of the Union Territory have carved out a unique identity in fields like ice hockey, winter sports, and mountaineering.

The PM said he was pleased that Ladakh is promoting sports talent through the new sports policy.

"Our effort is to ensure that the youth receive better training and facilities, and achieve new accomplishments at national and international levels," he said.

Addressing a long-standing regional demand for closer judicial access, Modi said the Government in August officially approved the establishment of a high court bench for Ladakh, and fulfilling this crucial institutional requirement will streamline both governance and legal recourse for the citizens. "This will make the justice system accessible alongside administration," he said.

Praising the craftsmanship of local artisans and farmers, the prime minister shared how he frequently gifts Ladakhi products to world leaders, including the German chancellor and the Swedish PM.

He stressed that the Government is actively strengthening Pashmina's global identity and expanding market branding for regional goods.

"Our effort is to ensure that local products get new markets, get better branding, and their benefits reach the producers directly," he said.

Expressing optimism about the UT's trajectory, Modi hoped that collective action would help the region reach unprecedented developmental milestones.

"Together, we will take Ladakh to new heights of development," he said.

# Pakistan drone drop in Rajasthan exposes terror-drug nexus, raises festive season alarms

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH ■ New Delhi/Jaipur

Early in the morning of 13th October, the Rajasthan Anti-Narcotics Task Force was on the lookout for what they expected to be another fairly routine narcotics drop along the India-Pakistan border. Instead, they found a terror consignment ready to go. It was located in a field near village 12 KD, Raola, Sri Ganganagar district, and comprised RDX, IEDs, pistols, remote detonators, batteries, and hundreds of rounds.

Three drones dropped the packages after flying about five kilometres from the international border. They were launched from a spot between five and ten kilometres inside Pakistan.

This discovery highlights an ongoing issue in the Sri Ganganagar area, where drones are often used at night to deliver heroin and other illegal goods. This time, though, the cargo was different. Investigators believe the materials were meant for a possible attack during the festive season or before elections in Punjab. They have not identified a specific target yet and are still working to trace the packages from where they were launched to their intended destination.

The flat terrain in Sri Ganganagar and its proximity to the border make it a common route for low-flying, short-range drones that sometimes evade radar detection. On the night of October 12th and 13th, visibility was low, similar to previous incidents that tested Indian border security. Local teams retrieved the packages before others could get to them, preventing the material from spreading further into the country.



Forensic tests on the RDX and remote detonation parts will be crucial. RDX is a powerful explosive usually found with military or state actors. The use of commercial batteries and remote triggers suggests a plan to quickly assemble and arm the devices once they reached local contacts. The pistols and large amount of ammunition point to a plan to equip small armed groups, not just build one big device. It is still unclear if the shipment was meant for a single major incident or to supply several groups. This incident also shows that drones serve more than one purpose along the border.

The same drones and drop methods used for smuggling drugs now seem to be used, or copied, to deliver explosives and weapons. Indian agencies have seen similar cases in Punjab and Rajasthan, where drug networks sometimes work with groups looking for help with their operations.

This recovery by itself does not prove a coordinated state operation. However, since the drones came from inside Pakistan and carried this kind of cargo, authorities will watch border security gaps and possible support networks even more closely.

Authorities have not shared details about the drones, like their type, how much they could carry, or how they were controlled. They also have not said if any signals or recovery attempts were noticed at the time. At first, the Anti-Narcotics Task Force thought the flight was for drug smuggling, which may have influenced their early response. If it is a counter-terrorism case, they need to work with state police, the Border Security Force, and central agencies. Questions remain about whether other flights like this have gone unnoticed in recent months and whether more hidden packages are out there.

# CBI arrests SFIO Deputy Director and two others in ₹1 crore bribery case linked to DHFL probe

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
New Delhi

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has arrested a Deputy Director-level officer from the Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO), along with two private individuals, including a Delhi-based advocate. They are accused of demanding ?1 crore to influence an ongoing SFIO investigation into the DHFL scam.

The CBI registered a case against the SFIO officer, who was posted in Chennai under the Ministry of Corporate Affairs, along with the advocate and others. They were accused of demanding ₹1 crore from a complainant to influence the SFIO's investigation into the DHFL case. After checking the complaint and filing an FIR, the agency set up a trap. The arrests were made when the advocate accepted ₹20 lakh from the complainant as part of the bribe, acting on behalf of the SFIO officer.




Searches of the public servant's and the advocate's homes and offices turned up material clearly connected to the case. The investigation is still in progress, with the CBI examining how the demand was made, the advocate's role as a middleman, and any other potential links.

This case involves the alleged misuse of official power within the SFIO, the agency responsible for investigating complex corporate fraud and serious financial crimes. The DHFL investigation has received significant attention because of the large amount of money involved and the number of parties connected to it.

In this situation, the complainant went to the CBI after being asked for money during the ongoing inquiry.

The trap, where part of the payment was handed over, led to the immediate arrests of the Deputy Director-level officer, the Delhi-based advocate, and the third private individual.

The material found during the searches is expected to be important evidence as the agency pieces together the communications and deals that led to the demand. Officials have not shared more details, such as the exact stage of the SFIO investigation or the complainant's identity, because the investigation is still ongoing.

These arrests show the CBI's push to curb corruption in agencies that handle major financial cases. The SFIO, part of the Ministry of Corporate Affairs, usually looks into large corporate groups. Claims of bribery in such cases raise questions about the fairness of the process. Here, the CBI checked the complaint, filed the FIR, and caught the accused while they took the ₹20 lakh payment.

The CBI has three accused in custody and is tracing the money, reviewing digital and paper records, and looking for others who may be involved.

The investigation is ongoing, and the CBI is expected to provide further updates as it reviews the evidence and the ₹1 crore demand.

# Actor Imran Khan to move Bombay High Court against leave India order

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Mumbai

Actor Imran Khan, a US citizen and an Overseas Citizen of India (OCI) cardholder, will move Bombay High Court challenging a notice issued by the Mumbai Police directing him to leave India by October 28 for allegedly violating rules by participating in a political demonstration.

The 43-year-old actor, OCI cardholder, is likely to file a petition in HC by Friday or Monday through his advocate Zulfiqar Memon.

In the draft petition, the actor has termed the "leave India" directive "drastic" and argued that no provision under the current law or statutory rules prohibits an OCI cardholder from participating in a peaceful protest.

Once filed, the plea is expected to be mentioned for an urgent hearing before a division bench comprising Chief Justice Mahesh Chandra Tripathi and Justice Advait Sethna. The police action follows Khan's brief detention during an agitation at Mumbai's August Kranti Maidan on October 10.



Imran Khan during a protest over Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar's resignation in Mumbai on October 10, 2026 FILE PHOTO

Protesters had gathered at the historical site in solidarity with a demonstration by Cockroach Janta Party in Delhi demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar over the SIR issue.

According to officials, Khan was served departure order after authorities invoked statutory provisions under Section 7 (2)(C) and Section 29 of The Immigration and Foreigners Act, which grant powers to the Government to restrict the movement of foreign nationals and enforce their mandatory removal.

# Determined to eliminate remaining traces of Naxalism: Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday said the Government is determined to eliminate the remaining traces of Naxalism and restore Bastar as a peaceful and prosperous region. He said efforts are being made to improve primary infrastructure and facilities in Chhattisgarh, where the Congress rule had failed to provide even basic amenities for decades.

Outlining the BJP Government's efforts to rebuild Bastar and rehabilitate victims of Left-Wing Extremism, Shah said eliminating Naxalism was not enough; the Government is also addressing the suffering it had caused over five decades, particularly among the region's poor tribal communities. Addressing virtually the distribution ceremony of assistive devices for Divyangjans, including those affected by Naxal violence, under the 'Seva Sankalp Abhiyan' organised to mark 25 years of Prime Minister Narendra Modi in public service, Shah said the end of Naxalism alone would not erase "five decades of suffering".



Home Minister Amit Shah virtually addresses a ceremony to provide assistance to Chhattisgarh's Naxal-affected people from New Delhi PTI

Under the campaign, assistive prosthetic devices are being provided in Chhattisgarh to make life easier for tribal persons with disabilities who have suffered as a result of Naxal violence, a Government statement said. Shah said Naxalism had inflicted immense suffering on the poor tribal communities of Bastar. Using IEDs to inflict disabilities on innocent civilians in pursuit of political objectives was the gravest violation of human rights, the minister said.

"We must heal the wounds inflicted by this suffering, help victims stand on their feet again, and ensure they can live with dignity and respect," he said.

Shah said under the Niyad Nellanar scheme, significant efforts had also been made to expand basic infrastructure and extend essential services to Bastar, which had remained deprived of such facilities under Congress Governments for five decades. He said the Government was determined to eliminate the "remaining traces of Naxalism" and restore Bastar as a peaceful and prosperous region. Shah said the Modi Government is committed to providing every person with a disability and every victim an opportunity for rehabilitation. Shah said the Centre stood firmly alongside the Chhattisgarh Government in supporting these efforts. "Traditional tribal leadership in the Bastar region had also made a major contribution," he said.

Shah said by providing persons with disabilities with wheelchairs, tricycles, crutches, hearing aids, smart walking sticks, artificial limbs and other assistive devices, the Government could help usher in a new era of hope and happiness in Bastar.

He said the Bastar Olympics has brought people together for sports in places where gunfire and bomb blasts once created an atmosphere of fear.

Through Bastar Pandum, the Government seeks to revive tribal art and culture, while the Niyad Nellanar scheme will improve basic facilities in remote areas, he said. He said that in a region where the sounds of gunfire and bomb blasts once prevailed, and fear was widespread, thousands of young people are now participating in sports and keeping their traditions alive.

He said bank accounts have been opened for 7,328 former Naxalites who do not have accounts."A total of 1,620 people have received reward money, 7,882 have received incentives, 455 have been provided jobs, and 129 have been allotted land.

In addition, under the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana, 4014 beneficiaries have received houses, and more than 2308 tribal people have undergone skill development training," he said.

# UPSIDA's 52nd board meet approves key growth proposals

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Lucknow

Uttar Pradesh State Industrial Development Authority (UPSIDA) approved key proposals on industrial land acquisition, industrial parks, land allotment policy reforms and infrastructure development at its 52nd Board Meeting held on Thursday under the chairmanship of Alok Kumar, Chairman of the UPSIDA Board and Additional Chief Secretary, Infrastructure and Industrial Development Department.

The decisions aim to strengthen Uttar Pradesh's industrial infrastructure, attract investment, improve administrative transparency and generate employment opportunities.



Alok Kumar

The Board approved proposals for additional expenditure on land purchases in Sandila tehsil, Hardoi, and Mau tehsil, Chitrakoot, along with land acquisition proposals in Hardoi and Mirzapur districts. It also approved a land exchange proposal for the proposed Lalitpur Pharma Park, to be developed under the Public-Private Partnership (PPP) model. The committee will refer the proposal to the next committee for further consideration. The project is expected to promote pharmaceutical manufacturing, research, investment and employment in the Bundelkhand region.

Land acquisition for Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited's (BPCL) LPG Bottling Plant and Bulk Dispatch Terminal in Kanpur Nagar was also approved, along with the related ex-post facto approval proposal.

The Board approved the layout plan for the Perfume Park in Kannauj and directed that industrial units on allotted plots begin operations at the earliest. It also approved the Model Building Regulations-2026 to bring greater uniformity and transparency to construction and development procedures.

To facilitate investors, the minimum qualifying score for plots over 500 square metres under UPSIDA's land allotment policy was reduced from 60 to 50 marks. The revised development plan for Trans Ganga City in Unnao was also approved, retaining the total green area while incorporating amenities such as a golf course, club and villas. Additionally, the Government will fill certain vacant engineering positions through deputation.

Alok Kumar emphasised the importance of industrial land availability, infrastructure development, transparent allotment procedures and simplified regulations. He expressed confidence that these measures would strengthen manufacturing, accelerate regional economic development and reinforce Uttar Pradesh's position as a major industrial hub.

# Rahul urges President to review Gautam's Governor appointment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Thursday wrote to President Droupadi Murmu to ask the Government to reconsider the appointment of Dushyant Gautam as governor till the CBI completes its probe into the Ankita Bhandari murder case.

In his letter to the President, Gandhi said he is writing to her as a "last resort" as she has the right to warn the Government and ask it to reconsider the advice to appoint Gautam as governor. Gautam was appointed the governor of Sikkim on Monday.

Gandhi also accused Prime Minister Narendra Modi of having no regard for women's safety by advising Gautam's appointment as governor. The parents of Ankita, who protested at India Gate on



Wednesday against the appointment, have alleged the involvement of Gautam in the 2022 murder case.

The Congress leader has said that no criminal proceedings can be instituted or continued against a governor and by appointing Gautam as governor places him "out of reach" of the CBI, which is probing the case.

The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | OCTOBER 16, 2026



## Editor's TAKE

# Hunger in a world of plenty

**On this World Food Day, the measure of progress must not be how much food the world produces, but how many people go to sleep hungry?**

There are several UN days that highlight important aspects of human life. But World Food Day, observed every year on 16 October, is special, as it affects all of humanity in one way or another. As they say, it is bad to die of thirst, but it is worse to die of thirst on a riverbank. That is exactly the case with food – we have enough to feed every mouth, but unfortunately, millions go hungry every day. The reason is that it never reaches them. Several factors are responsible for this – sometimes natural calamities, wars, unaffordability or simply a lack of awareness.

World Food Day is a reminder of this moral dyslexia: while enormous quantities of food are wasted at affluent gatherings or lost for want of adequate storage facilities, millions of people continue to suffer from hunger and malnutrition. The irony is particularly stark in developing nations, where food insecurity and nutritional deficiencies undermine health, stunt children's development and claim lives. The tragedy is not merely a shortage of food, but a failure to ensure that what is produced reaches those who need it most.

It marks the founding of the Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO) in 1945 and asks an uncomfortable question: why, in a world capable of feeding everyone, do millions still go to bed hungry? This year's theme, "Innovate today. Nourish tomorrow," is a call to turn science, technology, traditional knowledge and political will into food systems that are fair, resilient and sustainable. World Food Day is marked in about 150 countries. Its purpose is to raise awareness of hunger and malnutrition and to push for practical action on food, people and the planet. Its significance lies in its refusal to treat hunger as inevitable. The FAO notes that the world already produces enough food to nourish everyone, yet an estimated 645 million people faced hunger in 2025, while 2.69 billion could not afford a healthy diet. That contradiction is the scandal at the heart of the modern food economy.

Conflict, economic shocks and climate extremes continue to disrupt farming, supply chains and household incomes. In Africa, hunger remains especially severe, and projections warn that hundreds of millions may still face chronic undernourishment by 2030. Food security, therefore, is not merely an agricultural issue. It is a question of peace, climate justice, public health, gender equality and economic dignity.

Incremental charity cannot solve hunger. What is needed is a transformation of agrifood systems. World Food Day should not end with speeches. Governments must treat food as a national security priority. Businesses must shorten supply chains, reduce waste and pay fair prices. Consumers must waste less and support local producers. It is the least we can do to ensure that no one goes to bed hungry.

# Rahul's Satyagraha: The road to 2029

**With his new digital platform, Rahul Gandhi seeks to unite scattered protests, amplify marginalised voices and sharpen Congress's challenge to the Modi Government. The test lies in turning public discontent into a cohesive political movement and electoral gains in 2029**



KALYANI SHANKAR




A truly effective politician values long-term political influence and a lasting impact. Congress leader Rahul Gandhi also shares this understanding after many ups and downs.

One key aspect of Gandhi's plan is to engage directly with the public, as his grandmother did, and also to use digital platforms effectively. The launch of the 'Satyagraha' platform exemplifies this strategy. In a country where many voices — particularly those of marginalised communities such as students and farmers — are often overlooked, this initiative aims to amplify their concerns and promote inclusivity.

By giving people a platform to register protests and share their stories, Gandhi seeks to build a collective narrative that resonates with a broader audience.

Gandhi's approach questions the Government's narrative by engaging sympathetic media and sharing critical information about the ruling party. This strategy aims to create doubt even among Modi's strongest supporters, reflecting an understanding of how quickly public perception can change in the age of social media. Ultimately, he wants to shift the conversation to issues that matter to ordinary citizens.

Through the 'Satyagraha' initiative, Rahul Gandhi seeks to unite various voices and provide hope to those who feel overlooked.

Gandhi understands that if Modi is re-elected as Prime Minister in 2029, Congress may face even greater challenges in reclaiming power.

Through the 'Satyagraha' initiative, Rahul Gandhi aims to unite diverse voices and offer hope to those who feel marginalised.

On Saturday, Rahul Gandhi accused the Government of suppressing the truth and launched the 'Satyagraha' digital platform to unite various issue-based protests occurring across the country.

Launched the day after Mahatma Gandhi's 157th birthday, the 'Satyagraha' platform aims to support those facing injustice. "Satyagraha is an initiative designed to bring these voices together on one platform," he said in a post on X. Many individuals, including Gen Z, students and farmers, fight for their rights and often feel isolated. The platform encourages people to register their protests in support of those affected by oppression.

Around the country, various groups fight for their rights but often do so in isolation. Gen Z, students, farmers, Adivasis, Dalits and women each have unique struggles. It is often easier to silence a single voice.

GANDHI'S APPROACH QUESTIONS THE GOVERNMENT'S NARRATIVE BY ENGAGING SYMPATHETIC MEDIA AND SHARING CRITICAL INFORMATION ABOUT THE RULING PARTY. THIS STRATEGY AIMS TO CREATE DOUBT EVEN AMONG MODI'S STRONGEST SUPPORTERS, REFLECTING AN UNDERSTANDING OF HOW QUICKLY PUBLIC PERCEPTION CAN CHANGE IN THE AGE OF SOCIAL MEDIA

The writer is a popular columnist

At the party level, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra plans election strategies and drafts the party's manifesto, while Rahul Gandhi focuses on reaching the public and campaigning intensively. Gandhi's plans include direct-action protests, social media engagement and targeting younger voters, specifically Gen Z, along with women, Dalits, Other Backward Classes (OBCs), gig workers and the unemployed.

The first phase of Rahul Gandhi's initiative focuses on appointing new secretaries to the All India Congress Committee (AICC) to strengthen party operations across states. Strengthening the party's presence in key states such as Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Odisha and Maharashtra, where it has faced challenges, is crucial for a successful bid in 2029.

Rahul Gandhi is focusing on long-term political influence with his 'Satyagraha' initiative, aiming to engage directly with the public and amplify the voices of marginalised communities. Launched after Mahatma Gandhi's birthday, the platform encourages people, especially Gen Z, students, farmers and other underrepresented groups, to unite and share their struggles.

His strategy includes social media engagement, direct-action protests and targeting younger voters, alongside restructuring party operations to strengthen Congress in key states such as Uttar Pradesh and Maharashtra. Following the Bharat Jodo Yatra, Gandhi's approach has become more confrontational towards the Modi administration, positioning him as a key Opposition figure willing to challenge the Government boldly. He understands the importance of shifting public perception and intends to solidify his role and collaborate with supportive media in the lead-up to the 2029 elections.

Rahul Gandhi's 'Satyagraha' initiative seeks to unite diverse voices and inspire those who feel overlooked. It remains to be seen whether he can translate these plans into political success as India approaches a key election.

Gandhi understands the current political situation well. He recognises that if Modi is re-elected as Prime Minister in 2029, Congress may face even greater challenges in reclaiming power.

In the next three and a half years, Rahul Gandhi plans to solidify his position. He plans to collaborate with friendly media outlets.

He plans to engage Gen Z voters, ultimately helping develop a younger leadership team.

The Congress party has historically struggled with perceptions of Muslim appeasement, which has led many non-Muslim citizens to feel that Muslim leaders sway law and order. This focus on vote-bank politics over effective governance presents significant challenges for the party. Public opinion can shift quickly with economic conditions, government performance and political events, making opinion polls snapshots rather than reliable forecasts for future elections. With the 2029 general election not far away, India's political landscape could transform substantially.

The key question remains whether current shifts in public perception will endure or be short-lived. Ultimately, India's democratic process will decide the electoral outcome when voters go to the polls.

## Daiv Vani

WISDOM FOR A MEANINGFUL LIFE

# The Grace of Letting Go

Some of the deepest strength is shown not in fighting back, but in releasing what cannot be changed, without letting it harden the heart.

Sita endured abduction, prolonged captivity in Ravana's garden, a trial by fire to prove her purity, and later, painful banishment to the forest while pregnant, based on public doubt about her own conduct despite her unwavering devotion. Through every ordeal, she neither collapsed into despair nor hardened into permanent bitterness toward those who wronged her, including Rama himself. She raised her sons with dignity in sage Valmiki's hermitage, and when finally reunited with Rama, chose to return to the earth rather than prove her innocence yet again, releasing the need for continued vindication entirely.

Her strength lay not in loud resistance, but in her consistent refusal to let repeated injustice define who she remained at her core.

We often let one significant wrong done to us permanently shape our identity, carrying it forward as bitterness into every relationship that follows.

Today, identify one past hurt you're still carrying as bitterness, and consciously practice releasing its grip on how you see yourself now.

–DAIV

## PIC TALK



People take shelter under a plastic sheet during heavy rainfall as the IMD issues a red alert for rain, thunderstorms, lightning and gusty winds. PHOTO: PTI

# Wisdom or resistance to change?



SAKSHI SETHI

## 2ND OPINION

Experience is sometimes worn as a badge of indisputable authority in the hallways of education. These individuals are admired for their decades of classroom management, twenty years of teaching and thirty years of service. However, there is an awkward point that needs to be addressed: Does experience always equate to knowledge, or can it occasionally be used as a handy justification to oppose change? One of the rare occupations where using the same techniques for decades can still be misconstrued as career advancement is probably education. Even if a teacher has twenty-five years of experience, is that really twenty-five years of learning, or just one year repeated twenty-five times if classroom procedures, viewpoints and methods have not changed?

The difference is important.

Without question, experience imparts patience, insight and an awareness of the intricacies of the classroom. Experienced teachers frequently have knowledge that cannot be found in textbooks or training courses.

However, when experience becomes intolerant of younger viewpoints, dismissive of new ideas or resistant to introspection, it loses its instructional usefulness. Paradoxically, although schools support children's curiosity, experimentation, questioning and innovative thinking, instructors' own workplaces can hinder these same traits. A child's curiosity is celebrated, but instructors' inquiry is sometimes viewed as disobedience.

Young educators frequently bring new insights, confidence with technology and a passion for cutting-edge methods to the teaching profession. However, seniority may be used to measure their accomplishments rather than merit. Sometimes, well-known rebuttals to suggestions are used, such as "We have always done it this way" or "You will understand when you gain experience." A troubling conflict is revealed by such remarks. Why should educators themselves become reluctant learners if education is really about learning? The issue is not limited to specific courses. The leadership of the school must likewise face its obligations. Organisations may designate coordinators, implement complex administrative frameworks and hold workshops for professional growth. However, real cooperation cannot be replaced by titles. Innovation becomes little more than a catchphrase in institutional presentations when communication is still disjointed, duties are not well integrated and professional hierarchies stifle discussion.

Adopting technology, implementing smart classrooms or setting up training sessions is not enough to make a school innovative. The propensity to conflate unthinking obedience with professional respect is also troubling. Respect must continue to be reciprocal, but seniority deserves recognition. To gain professional legitimacy, younger instructors should not have to give up their uniqueness or inventiveness. However, innovation should not be used as a justification for ignoring experience. New strategies must be implemented carefully, and seasoned educators can offer the discernment required to separate significant advancements from passing fads in education.

A conflict between seasoned and up-and-coming educators is not necessary for the future of education. It necessitates a collaboration in which innovation keeps knowledge from becoming outdated and wisdom directs innovation.

The willingness to keep learning over the years may be a better indicator of an educator's worth than the number of years they have spent in the classroom. After all, a teacher who stops learning runs the risk of losing the essential essence of education, even though they can still teach lessons.

The writer is an educator and counsellor

# LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

### IDBI Bank and the push for disinvestment

The sale of a 60.72 per cent stake in IDBI Bank to Fairfax Financial Holdings reflects the BJP Government's policy that 'commercial banking is not a core state function'. Established in 1964 as a Development Financial Institution (DFI), IDBI Bank aimed to support heavy industries, manufacturing plants and infrastructure projects, boosting economic development. However, following economic liberalisation in the early 1990s, commercial banks began offering project finance, making the role of DFIs less relevant. Consequently, in 2005, IDBI merged with its banking subsidiary to offer retail, corporate and commercial banking services.

Legacy projects turned into NPAs, causing heavy losses and RBI restrictions. The Government and LIC infused nearly ₹49,000 crore to revive the bank.With the bank returning to profitability, the Government is now disinvesting its stake. In the coming years, more government-owned entities may be sold to private owners. The message is clear: if public sector and wholly government-owned companies are deemed unviable, they may be sold, whether in banking, insurance, airlines, telephony or other sectors.

V JAYARAMAN | CHENNAI

### The right to protest

Since when has holding the national flag high become a "crime" in this country? This question arises following the arrest and imprisonment of Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka in Tihar Jail for holding the Tricolour and raising the slogan "Bharat Mata ki Jai" at the iconic Jantar Mantar.

No place on Indian soil, including one denotified as a designated protest site, should be off-limits to citizens wishing to wave the national flag. Holding the Tricolour as an act of resistance cannot be treated as a punishable offence. The CJP leaders are within their rights to "sneak" into Jantar Mantar and reclaim the popular protest site.

Their imprisonment is all the more striking because it has been carried out by a ruling dispensation that claims a "patent on nationalism". It indicates that the Government may be using its authority to silence dissent for political reasons. The incarceration of these young leaders, instead of engaging with them, illustrates that all is not well with our democracy.

Any political system that refuses to allow protests risks becoming tyrannical. Preserving space for peaceful dissent is essential to the continued existence of democracy.

G DAVID MILTON | MARUTHANCODE

### Turning Kalam's vision into reality

This refers to the editorial "Kalam's Unfinished Dream: A Developed India" (October 15). APJ Abdul Kalam's vision of a developed India remains relevant, but his legacy demands more than speeches and ceremonies. His belief in young people must translate into measurable reforms in education, research, employment and social development. His legacy should be judged by improvements in people's lives. Schools must develop critical thinking, practical skills and problem-solving abilities, while colleges need better laboratories, research facilities and industry partnerships. Rural and disadvantaged students must receive quality education through improved infrastructure, digital access and targeted support. Education must be supported by policies that promote sustainable development, research, entrepreneurship, employment, affordable healthcare, environmental protection and equal opportunities.

Kalam's dream requires accountable institutions, capable citizens and sustained public investment. Policymakers must set clear targets and ensure that economic growth benefits all sections of society. His best tribute would be meaningful reforms that nurture young minds, reward merit and promote equal opportunities, social inclusion and environmental responsibility.

ABBHARNA BARATHI | CHENNAI

The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | OCTOBER 16, 2026



# El Niño's 'Godzilla' warning: Climate change turns up the heat

**A fossil-fuel-driven climate crisis is intensifying El Niño, threatening to unleash harsher droughts, floods and heatwaves. With India already grappling with rainfall deficits and drought-hit regions, the warning is clear: climate adaptation must begin on farms and in reservoirs, even as the world accelerates its transition to clean energy**



BK SINGH

El Niño occurs naturally every two to seven years, as the waters of the tropical Pacific Ocean warm, affecting weather patterns around the world. Among the strong El Niño patterns observed over the past few decades, the current one, informally known as 'Godzilla', is brewing and threatening to supercharge weather patterns around the world. A new study published in Science has found that the burning of fossil fuels has been contributing to the strongest El Niño events in living memory.

Julia Cole, a climate researcher at the University of Michigan who led the study, says, "Our findings suggest El Niño can supercharge global warming and also global warming can supercharge El Niño — that is what we are seeing." The climate phenomenon, which brings a rise in global temperatures, further amplifies the worsening climate crisis. The years 2026 and even 2027 are projected to be the hottest on record. The research has concluded that human-caused global heating is making El Niño more intense. In the future, whenever El Niño is predicted, we must be prepared for the possibility of severe conditions, with its intensity potentially influenced by the burning of fossil fuels.

The lead author, Cole, added, "We are seeing a trend of stronger El Niños and the one we have now is consistent with that trend — it is not a fluke. We are seeing a shift where El Niño does not look like what it did prior to Industrial times. That is bad news for climate hazards and for people, particularly those who are badly impacted and yet have done little to cause climate change."

In a warming world, past El Niño events over the last three decades have provided additional acceleration to the rise in global temperatures. During the study, scientists analysed the composition of large, boulder-like deposits of coral fossils found in the Galápagos Islands. These islands are situated off the coast of mainland Ecuador, a country that has faced severe El Niño conditions, causing the surrounding waters to warm. The corals died about a thousand years ago, and their chemical compositions indicate the range of sea surface temperatures when they were alive. The study found that El Niño remained stable until industrialisation began about 150 years ago. The data from the study conclude that El Niño variability is 37 per cent higher than it was in the pre-industrial era, indicating that the phenomenon has become more intense over the last 40 years.

"After El Niño in 1982, we started seeing much more variability; it is a lot more extreme and looks like nothing in the previous thousand years," said Cole. The other members of the study ruled out random or naturally occurring causes for the acceleration. The findings have addressed a key question in climate science: whether global warming caused by fossil fuel burning is altering the strength of El Niño events. Another co-author of the study, Samantha Stevenson-Karl, a scientist at the University of California, Santa Barbara, said, "It is a strong indication that climate change may already be amplifying El Niño events……If that's true then really the large events like the one that seems to be brewing in the tropical Pacific right now might become more common in the future."

In such a scenario, different regions of the world are being considerably affected by heatwaves, wildfires and floods. As El Niño becomes more intense, partly due to changes in the trade winds, surface temperatures in the western Pacific rise, bringing heavier rainfall and floods to the southern USA and South America. Countries such as Indonesia, Australia and India face drier conditions, significantly affecting food production and pushing 50 million people worldwide into hunger. Countries must take steps to adapt to these events by stockpiling food. Wildfires in Indonesia this year have brought haze and smoke into the lower atmosphere of neighbouring countries such as Singapore, Malaysia and the Philippines, posing severe health hazards. However, the real solution is to transition away from burning fossil fuels.

The south-west monsoon in India is already showing signs of suppression, with rainfall deficits in peninsular India and some regions of central India. Recent rains in northern India, across the Gangetic Plain, have eliminated the deficit but caused severe flooding in the region. This is a double whammy: the delayed monsoon in northern India has reduced agricultural sowing and planting areas, affecting food production, while also causing considerable hardship as some regions have remained under floodwater for over two weeks, damaging standing crops.



REPRESENTATIVE IMAGE

NEARLY 40 PER CENT OF THE COUNTRY HAS EXPERIENCED RAINFALL DEFICITS, PARTICULARLY IN MAHARASHTRA, KARNATAKA, TELANGANA, ANDHRA PRADESH AND SIZEABLE PARTS OF RAJASTHAN. KARNATAKA HAS DECLARED 177 OF ITS 240 TALUKS DROUGHT-AFFECTED. MORE TALUKS ARE ALSO LIKELY TO BE ADDED TO THE LIST. THE STATE HAS TAKEN PRECAUTIONS TO MAINTAIN SUFFICIENT WATER IN ITS RESERVOIRS FOR DRINKING PURPOSES UNTIL JUNE 2027. WHILE COMPLYING WITH THE TRIBUNAL'S DIRECTIVE, WATER FROM THE CAUVERY RESERVOIRS HAS BEEN RELEASED TO TAMIL NADU

Nearly 40 per cent of the country has experienced rainfall deficits, particularly in Maharashtra, Karnataka, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh and sizeable parts of Rajasthan. Karnataka has declared 177 of its 240 taluks drought-affected. More taluks are also likely to be added to the list. The state has taken precautions to maintain sufficient water in its reservoirs for drinking purposes until June 2027. While complying with the tribunal's directive, water from the Cauvery reservoirs has been released to Tamil Nadu. The state has also released water from reservoirs in the Krishna basin to Telangana. The water situation in Karnataka is quite stressful.

The Maharashtra Government has imposed a 10 per cent water cut in all urban and rural local bodies from 16 October amid a deficient monsoon. They have also been asked to ensure that treated wastewater is used for gardening, construction and washing instead of fresh water. Industries have been directed to reuse or recycle at least 30 per cent of the water they consume. Earlier, on 26 September, the state government declared drought in 265 of 358 taluks across 32 districts, accounting for 74 per cent of the state's area. The state has also decided to maintain a buffer stock of 10 per cent in each dam, in addition to the water required for drinking purposes until August 2027. Evaporation, silt and unauthorised extraction of water have also been considered in the calculations.

Across the country, groundwater has been pumped out to supplement the water required for paddy cultivation. In such circumstances, underground aquifers are not recharged at the same pace, resulting in many borewells drying up. The Union Agriculture Ministry and state governments have been running awareness campaigns encouraging people to grow dry crops such as maize and other millets, but these efforts have not been successful on the ground. People must realise that the Government cannot make up for rainfall deficits, and cloud seeding is not a viable option. Stubble burning in paddy fields in Haryana, Punjab, Uttar Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh, where crops are now ready for harvest, could pose severe environmental and health hazards.

People must adapt to the circumstances and opt for millets instead of paddy. As El Niño conditions are likely to persist into the first half of 2027, farmers must also adopt soil and moisture conservation measures on their farmland.

Farm ponds must be rejuvenated to help conserve water. The inlet drains leading to water bodies and agricultural land must be cleared, and vegetation in catchment areas must be preserved. More trees should be planted in degraded catchment areas, as this helps reduce monsoon run-off during rainfall and conserve soil moisture.

As El Niño is found to be intensified by fossil fuel burning, the only long-term solution is to transition towards renewable and cleaner energy.

The writer is a former Head of Forest Force, Karnataka

# *Aharo Mahabhaishajyam:* Food is the great medicine



ABHISHEK ANAND

Today, World Food Day, is a good occasion to discover, explore and highlight how Ancient Bharat developed a sophisticated, systematic dietetics in which food was not merely fuel, pleasure or ritual but a primary instrument for maintaining health, preventing disease and supporting the treatment of ailments. This idea is captured in the celebrated maxim *Aharo Mahabhaishajyam* ("food is the great medicine"). In Ayurveda, ahara entails and encompasses not only what we eat but also how, when, how much, in what season and in what physical and mental state.

## Food as first therapy

Ayurveda places ahara among the *trayo'pastambha*, i.e., the three "sub-pillars" of life, along with *nidra* (sleep) and *brahmacharya* (regulated conduct). In this worldview, good health is not accidental; it is sustained daily through disciplined living. Food is, therefore, both nourishment and a health intervention. The *Charaka Samhita* states that the body, disease and well-being depend fundamentally on nutrition. Improper food can generate disorder while appropriate food can restore balance.

*Aharo Mahabhaishajyam* should be perceived correctly. It does not mean that every meal cures every illness, nor that diet can replace surgery, antibiotics, insulin or emergency care. Rather, it means that food is a constant medicine. Taken three or four times a day, it continuously shapes digestion, metabolism, immunity, energy, health and long-term disease risk.



## Ancient Indian dietetics

What makes ancient Indian food wisdom apt, distinctive and compelling is that it treats eating as a complete system rather than mere delicacies and nutrients.

**Individual suitability:** *Ayurveda* takes cognisance of the fact that the same food does not affect everyone the same way. Diet should be adjusted to one's constitution (*prakriti*), digestive capacity (*agni*), age and pathological state. This anticipates a cardinal concern of modern personalised nutrition: individual variability in metabolism and dietary response.

**Quantity and timing:** The *Charaka Samhita* underlines the *ashta ahara vidhi visheshayatana* (eight determinants of the effect of food): the nature of the food, processing, combination, quantity, place, time, rules of intake and the person consuming it.

**Season and place:** Ancient dietetics is deeply ecological and Indian cuisine is a living archive of ecological awareness and consciousness. Food recommendations change with *ritu* (season) and *desha* (region).

**Wholesome and unwholesome food:** The categories of *pathya* and apathya (wholesome and unwholesome) are salient. *Pathya* is not simply "healthy food" in a generic sense; it is food suitable for a particular person, condition, season and therapeutic goal. This is why Ayurvedic treatment often begins with dietary correction before or alongside medicinal treatment.

## Indian kitchen as a therapeutic laboratory

**Grains, pulses and balanced meals:** The traditional Indian platter (*thali*) often combines cereals and legumes: rice with *dal*, *roti* with *rajma* or *chana*, millet porridges with buttermilk and regional preparations using locally available grains. This blending provides amino acids, fibre, micronutrients and slow-release carbohydrates.

**Fermentation and gut health:** Bharat's culinary heritage includes *idli*, *dosa*, *dhokla*, *kanji*, buttermilk, pickles and regional fermented gruels. Fermentation can improve digestibility, preserve food, enhance flavour and, in some cases, increase nutrient bioavailability. Modern research has increasingly begun to recognise the gut microbiome as a major regulator of metabolism and immunity. Ancient Indian physicians' attention to *agni* reflects a practical understanding that the same food may nourish or burden depending on the state of digestion.

**Spices as functional foods:** Indian spices are not merely flavouring agents. Turmeric, ginger, black pepper, cumin, coriander, fenugreek, cardamom, cinnamon, clove, and asafoetida have long been used in culinary and therapeutic situations.

**Ghee, oils and fats:** *Ghee* has a contested reputation but in *Ayurveda*, it is valued for its digestibility, lubricating quality and role as a carrier for herbs. The wiser interpretation is not that "ghee cures disease" but that traditional fats were used in measured, context-specific ways alongside fibre-rich foods, spices and active lifestyles. The problem in many modern diets is not fat alone but refined carbohydrates, ultra-processed foods and excess calories.

## From diet to disease control

How can ancient ingredients inform and guide modern medicine? The answer lies in integration, not substitution. Ancient Indian dietetics furnishes five tenets for modern preventive medicine:

**Food is preventive medicine:** Diet influences the risk factors for obesity, type 2 diabetes, cardiovascular disease, fatty liver and some cancers.

**Context matters:** Quantity, timing, preparation, combination, season and individual condition affect outcomes.

**Whole dietary patterns outperform single ingredients:** The *thali*, comprising grain, pulse, vegetable, fermented or dairy component, spice, and fat, assimilates and showcases dietary diversity.

**Culinary processing is therapeutic knowledge:** Soaking, sprouting, fermenting, roasting, tempering and pairing foods with spices are not incidental customs; they impact digestibility, taste, preservation and nutrient availability.

**Evidence must be earned:** Traditional use and cultural continuity should inspire inquiry but claims must be validated through accurate, authentic, reliable and credible information tested against evidence.

Ancient Bharat's understanding of *ahara* reminds us that a civilisation's kitchen can be as much an archive of knowledge as its texts and monuments. *Aharo Mahabhaishajyam* is not a claim that food replaces medicine; it is a durable insight that health is built daily through what, how, when and where we eat, and that this insight deserves to be validated and carried forward through research.

This is precisely the spirit of *Bharat Ki Soch*: to look to our civilisational roots, not out of nostalgia but to draw from them wisdom that can contribute to Bharat's growth story.

The writer is Senior Research Fellow, Bharat Ki Soch

# Chhattisgarh's Mitanins: Delivering last-mile healthcare



ABHA MISHRA

The success of a state's healthcare system cannot be measured only by its hospital count, its machines or its doctors. What really matters is whether a sick child in a remote village, a woman in labour or a patient with suspected malaria gets access to medical help in time. In Chhattisgarh's forested regions, last-mile healthcare delivery depends heavily on one group of women, the Mitanins. Nearly 72,000 Mitanins are the link that brings healthcare within reach of villages where hospitals are far, travel is hard and awareness is still limited.

A Mitanin is more than a link between the health department and rural families. She is someone the community trusts. Her work spans the care of pregnant women, child immunisation, newborn health and carrying information about government health schemes into homes that might otherwise never hear of them. In tribal communities, where women often find it hard to speak openly about health concerns, a Mitanin from the same village becomes an easier person to talk to. When needed, she helps get a patient to hospital and guides the family through treatment.

Chhattisgarh launched the Mitanin programme in 2002. The model later went on to shape the national ASHA worker network, demonstrating how essential community participation is to reaching the last person in the healthcare chain. But sustaining that effectiveness takes more than good intentions. It needs training, timely incentive payments, access to medicines and resources, and working conditions that respect what these women do.

Continued financial support is an important part of sustaining this network. The Chhattisgarh government has taken steps to ensure continued financial support for Mitanins and ensure timely and transparent payments. Allocation for the Mitanin Welfare Fund (Mitanin Kalyan Kosh) rose from ₹111 crore in 2023-24 to ₹325.5 crore in 2024-25 and ₹336.8 crore in 2025-26. For 2026-27, ₹350 crore is proposed for the fund. This increase signals the state's strong commitment to the programme.



The payment system itself has also changed. Earlier, payments were often delayed at the block level and workers had difficulty in tracking how different components added up. Now, a state-level online system sends money directly into bank accounts, with a Mitanin passbook setting out the central, state and individual shares of each payment clearly.

A Mitanin's responsibilities are not confined to any single illness or programme. They run from routine immunisation and maternal and child health to spreading awareness about malaria, tuberculosis and diarrhoea. During the COVID pandemic, Mitanins carried out community-level surveys, informed people about precautions and encouraged vaccination. When a health system faces a crisis, it is this local network that carries government guidance door to door.

Bastar's progress against malaria is a notable example of the importance of Mitanins. For years, difficult terrain, forest villages and poor access to health centres kept malaria a persistent challenge there. It is now moving toward being malaria-free. Mitanins went house to house during the elimination campaign, testing residents with rapid diagnostic kits, identifying likely cases, building awareness and encouraging people to complete their full course of medication. The positivity rate of Bastar, 4.6 per cent at the campaign's start, fell to 0.46 per cent by June 2024.

After November 2024, the government targeted roughly 16.77 lakh people across 2,527 villages in Bastar's seven sensitive districts along with Gariaband, Khairagarh-Chhuikhadan-Gandai and Kawardha. The target was successfully met by Mitanins and Bastar's annual cases later dropped significantly from 27.40 to 7.11. Meanwhile, the statewide rate declined from 2.63 in 2018 to 0.90 by 2025.

Mitanins have completely changed healthcare for mothers and babies in the rural regions of Chhattisgarh. Because of their dedication alongside overall healthcare upgrades, infant deaths declined from 95 to 37 per 1,000 between 2000 and 2024. Maternal deaths dropped from 159 to 124 per 100,000 by 2026. While better clinics and nutrition helped, Mitanins continued to remain the vital mediators that connect families to life-saving medical care.

Chhattisgarh's Mitanin network provides an important lesson for public health. Investment in hospitals and equipment is essential, but it delivers real value only when people know when to seek treatment, can reach a health centre and complete their course of care. That depends on local trust and sustained engagement. Mitanins are the ones that build that trust and convert it into action. The road to a healthier Chhattisgarh runs through its hospitals, but it begins with the Mitanin in the village whom a family turns to when they need help.

The writer is Director, Policy Watch India Foundation

The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | OCTOBER 16, 2026



# India flags anti-India hate after US temple attack

**ASHOKE RAJ** ■ New Delhi




India has expressed deep concern over an alleged plot to carry out a mass shooting at a Hindu temple in Aurora, Illinois, and called on US authorities to conduct a thorough investigation and bring those responsible to justice.

In a statement issued on Thursday, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said the reported anti-Hindu and racist motives behind the alleged plot were particularly disturbing, especially references to violence against people of Indian origin.

The ministry said it had taken note of the action initiated by US law enforcement agencies, including the arrest of the suspect and the charges filed against him. It added that the incident had intensified concerns over racist hostility and anti-India hate in the United States.

The MEA called for greater vigilance, a zero-tolerance approach to hate-motivated violence and decisive measures to protect the Indian community. It also urged US authorities to ensure accountability and take steps to prevent similar incidents. The statement followed reports that an alleged attempt to carry out a mass shooting at the Hindu temple was thwarted after the suspect's rifle reportedly malfunctioned. According to authorities, the 19-year-old suspect, identified as Paporakis, allegedly told a co-worker that he had visited the temple on Saturday and attempted to open fire, but his weapon failed to discharge.

The suspect was arrested outside his residence in Palatine on Sunday after the co-worker alerted the police. Authorities in Mount Prospect received the information and subsequently passed it on to Palatine law enforcement officials.

The accused appeared before a court in Rolling Meadows on Wednesday, local time, and was charged with making a terrorist threat and unlawful possession of weapons. A judge ordered him to remain in custody until October 30, when he is scheduled to appear in court again.

Police said a search of the suspect's residence led to the recovery of a rifle, loaded magazines, hundreds of rounds of ammunition and body armour. Palatine Police Chief William Nord said the body armour featured designs associated with white supremacist extremism. Prosecutors alleged that the suspect contacted his co-worker through a text message on Sunday and asked for a phone call. During the conversation, he reportedly admitted that he had attempted the shooting but could not fire his rifle. The suspect also allegedly sent the co-worker a photograph of himself wearing a tactical vest and an eight-page document titled "Why I Fought: A.K.A.: (Aurora Shooter's Manifesto)."

Court documents described the document as containing racist statements targeting people of Indian descent and the Hindu temple. Prosecutors alleged that the suspect had expressed an intention to kill members of minority communities and had been planning the attack for approximately two years.

Chief Nord said the writings contained extremist ideologies and references to mass violence. Officials also reported expressions of hatred towards Jewish people and other non-white communities, including African Americans.

Police said the Federal Bureau of Investigation assisted investigators in accessing the suspect's electronic devices and communications as part of the investigation.

# Hezbollah claims explosives, denies assassination plot

**ASSOCIATED PRESS** ■ Beirut


Hassan Fadlallah

A Hezbollah official acknowledged on Thursday that a truck full of explosives seized by Lebanese authorities last week belonged to the militant group and said the explosives were intended for use against Israeli forces in southern Lebanon.

The truck, which was stopped at a checkpoint on the main highway linking Beirut with the eastern Bekaa Valley, was carrying 780 kilograms (1,720 pounds) of explosives, including 250 kilograms (550 pounds) of TNT and 250 kilograms (550 pounds) of C-4 plastic explosives, according to judicial officials.

Two men were arrested when the truck was stopped, and Lebanese authorities launched an investigation. They said that security agencies will go after other people involved in the shipment.

The news of its seizure had generated heated public discussions, with many accusing Hezbollah of planning to carry out assassinations of domestic opponents at a time when the group is under increasing pressure to disarm. Prime Minister Nawaf Salam noted that C-4 explosives had been used in several "infamous political assassinations in Lebanon's modern history."

Hassan Fadlallah, a member of Hezbollah's parliamentary bloc, in a statement Thursday acknowledged that the truck was transporting materials for the group. He said the explosives were "intended exclusively for use against the Israeli occupation" in southern Lebanon and called the allegations that they were part of an assassination plot "baseless."

"It is well known that (Hezbollah's) weapons include explosive devices - a subject the enemy has frequently addressed and whose impact it deeply fears," the statement said.

# Globalisation cannot be reversed, but it must be navigated with resilience: EAM

**PRESS TRUST OF INDIA**
■ Abu Dhabi



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar speaks during a session of the Raisina Dialogue's Middle East edition in Abu Dhabi PTI

Globalisation cannot be reversed, but it must be navigated with greater resilience, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said on Thursday, underlining that India is building its own strengths and establishing trusted partnerships. Jaishankar made these remarks during a discussion on 'The Continental Corridors: Who Connects the Heartland?' at the Raisina Dialogue's Middle East edition in Abu Dhabi.

The panel also included Mehdi Jomaa, former prime minister of Tunisia; Rizwan Soomar, CEO and Managing Director for DP World; and Armida van Rij, senior research fellow at the Centre for European Reform in London. Speaking at the forum, Jaishankar said that competition had intensified, new chokepoints have emerged, and the willingness to leverage advantages has grown. His comments come amid a volatile situation in West Asia, with vessels coming under repeated attacks in the Strait of Hormuz, a key maritime chokepoint, which has been under strain since the US-Iran war.

"Globalisation cannot be reversed, but it must be navigated with greater resilience," Jaishankar said. Referring to the India–Middle East–Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC), he said it is already shaping regional thinking on connectivity.

# Heavy rain shuts down Istanbul

**ASSOCIATED PRESS** ■ Istanbul

A heavy downpour has shut down Istanbul, flooded homes and roads and killed at least three people, officials said Thursday, as rescuers worked overnight to save hundreds of people stranded at their workplaces.

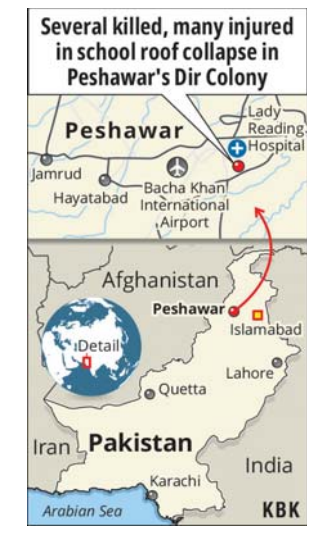
The downpour Wednesday night flooded homes and businesses and inundated roads and underpasses, stranding vehicles and causing traffic chaos in Turkiye's largest city.

The Istanbul governor's office on Thursday reported three deaths in the city and said four other people were reported missing. A 14-year-old was electrocuted after stepping in a puddle at a park in the Fatih district, and a 34-year-old slipped on a sidewalk in the Sariyer district and hit their head, local media reports said. The governor's office said the body of a third victim was discovered near another park in the Kagithane district.

Interior Minister Mustafa Ciftci said that more than 2,700 people who were stranded by the floods were safely evacuated. The Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality said that some areas had highest amount of rain since 1985. In Sakarya province, around 150 km (93 miles) east of Istanbul, a two-storey house that was built on a riverbed collapsed in floods, HaberTurk television reported.

# 34 children, teacher killed as school roof collapses in Pakistan

**PRESS TRUST OF INDIA**
■ Peshawar




At least 34 children and a teacher were killed when the roof of a private school collapsed on Thursday in Peshawar, the capital of Pakistan's Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, hospital authorities and police said. The incident occurred in Dir Colony in the congested inner city area, Peshawar Capital City Police chief Mian Saeed said. Thirty students were present in classrooms on the upper floor of the Al-Khair School when the roof collapsed, he said.

The owner, who was operating the institution as an education trust, has been arrested, he said, adding that the roof of the three-storey building was poorly constructed. Thirty-two children and a teacher were brought dead to the Lady Reading Hospital (LRH) in Peshawar, hospital spokesperson Muhammad Asim told PTI.

Two bodies were shifted to Naseerullah Khan Babar Memorial Hospital in the city.

Asim said 20 injured children were also brought to the LRH hospital. Most of them were discharged after first aid. Three critically injured children, who sustained head injuries, had been admitted to the hospital, he added.

An emergency was declared at the hospital to treat the injured, Asim said, adding that all of the children killed or injured in the incident were age 13 or younger.

Peshawar Deputy Commissioner Afaq Wazir said all people trapped beneath the debris have been rescued. He also ordered a probe into the building collapse. Provincial Education Secretary Inayatullah Waseem directed the managing director of the Private Schools Regulatory Authority to submit a report on the incident by Friday.

According to the city police chief, the building was located in narrow streets, which made rescue operations difficult. He said the authorities will examine which building regulations had been violated and conduct a proper inquiry into the incident to determine responsibility for the negligence.

Pakistan Army personnel, alongside other rescue and relief agencies, actively participated in the rescue operation. Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Inspector General of Police (IGP) Zulfiqar Hameed directed the Peshawar Chief Traffic Officer to establish a green corridor to ensure uninterrupted movement of ambulances.

President Asif Ali Zardari and Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif expressed deep grief over the loss of life in the mishap and extended condolences to the bereaved families. Sharif prayed for the speedy recovery of the injured and directed authorities to provide the best possible medical treatment to them. National Assembly Speaker Sardar Ayaz Sadiq expressed solidarity with the bereaved families and prayed for the speedy recovery of those injured. KPK Governor Faisal Karim Kundi expressed grief over the roof collapse and directed the relevant authorities to determine the cause of the incident.

Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) Chairman Bilawal Bhutto Zardari expressed deep grief over the deaths, saying he was deeply shocked by tragic news.

# Commercial goods will not enter Gaza Strip, says Israel

**SAM METZ/BASSEM MROUE**
■ Jerusalem



Israel said that commercial goods will no longer enter the Gaza Strip, cutting off a key source of food and shelter supply for the war-torn territory as hungry Palestinians face the approach of winter.

COGAT, the Israeli military body that oversees humanitarian affairs in Gaza, announced the suspension of commercial goods in a Wednesday statement. It was not clear whether they made the decision. COGAT said it was relaying a statement from Gaza merchants, a claim Palestinians refuted.

The move stands to immediately reduce Gaza's supplies, because the closed-off territory is completely reliant on whatever goods Israel allows in through border crossings. The suspension also raised fears about affordability, with humanitarian workers saying a combination of aid and a robust commercial market is needed to keep prices under control. "The humanitarian sector on its own cannot meet the needs of all the people," said Shaina Low, a spokesperson for the Norwegian Refugee Council, an aid group. "The markets need to be functioning." The world's leading authority on food insecurity reported earlier this year that conditions in Gaza had improved since famine was declared in the territory in August 2025, but were still at crisis levels. Most families in the war-battered enclave weren't getting nearly enough to eat, said the report, adding that "even small disruptions to humanitarian access could rapidly reverse recent gains."

In announcing the measure, COGAT claimed to be communicating a decision made by local merchants in Gaza who had grown tired of Hamas taxing their trucks and threatening them. Israel has long accused the militant group of levying fees on imports to fund its operations. But the head of Gaza's private truckers union, Nahed Sheheiber, disputed that, saying Israel had made the decision.

"The merchants are not the ones who stopped the shipments," he said. "The Israeli coordinator is claiming that Gaza's merchants are responsible, but the truth is that the Israelis are the ones who imposed the restrictions."

Following COGAT's announcement, Shehaiber's union met with Gaza's Ministry of Economy to express concern and say Israel was citing fees levied by the ministry as a pretext to cut off commercial goods. The ministry had been asking merchants to pay 10,000 shekels (about $3,226) per truck entering Gaza, Shehaiber said. At the meeting, ministry Undersecretary Khaled Al-Raqab told the union that the amount was not a tax, but rather a donation sought by the ministry to help pay civil servants in the strip.

It was not clear from the COGAT announcement if aid agencies would be allowed to increase shipments into Gaza to compensate for the loss in commercial goods. (*AP*)

# Partnership with India combines trust with technology: UK AI minister

**ADITI KHANNA** ■ London


Britain's Minister for Artificial Intelligence (AI) Kanishka Narayan

The UK and India are two countries geared towards adoption of new technologies and the partnership proves that there is no trade-off between building trust and technology, according to Britain's Minister for Artificial Intelligence (AI) Kanishka Narayan.

The British Indian Cabinet minister was the keynote speaker at the annual Indo-European Business Forum (IEBF) awards at the House of Lords complex in London on Wednesday evening.

The event was themed around a celebration of the three-month mark of the implementation of the India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA). "You often hear there's a trade-off between building trust and building technology," said Narayan. "I feel very strongly that the thing that the UK and India do deeply is to reject that trade-off; instead to say that you only build trust in the long term if you build technology in your country, and as a result of it, are able to shape it with your values as well.

"And that is why the efforts that India is making in semiconductor design, assembly, testing, packaging, but at the crux of it, respectively, also manufacturing is so important. It's also why we are very focused in this country, both on developing models, developing the frontier of semiconductors and hardware as well," he said.

The Muzaffarpur-born MP from Wales touched upon his "personal story" as he highlighted that the most compelling part of the connection between India and the UK is that they are "two countries that are chasing the future" with a "very distinct focus on adoption" of new technologies. "It is pretty hard to not feel that when you're visiting India and walking around, and even in the smallest of towns. I grew up in a small town in Bihar, and you walk around and you see every single person with a smartphone and a vastly outsized dream compared to the size of their smartphone," said Narayan, one of the youngest ministers in the UK Cabinet.

The IEBF event, hosted in Parliament by Baroness Sandy Verma, opened with an address by UK Minister for the Indo-Pacific in the Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office (FCDO) Baroness Rosie Winterton.

"The trade deal has opened the door to a new era in our country's partnership, and our job now is to make sure we seize them by building new connections and find new ways to work together," said Winterton. "An agreement is only the beginning. Its true success lies in turning opportunities into investment, commercial partnerships and growth for businesses of all sizes. At IEBF, we are committed to making this happen by bringing together business leaders, policymakers and investors to turn shared ambitions into tangible results," said IEBF Founder Vijay Goel. A tribute to G P Hinduja, the chair of the Hinduja Group conglomerate who passed away in London last year aged 85, was followed by an awards ceremony honouring singer Kanika Kapoor as the India-UK Cultural Ambassador.

Other awards handed out for 2026 included Business Man of the Year to Sanfran Group Director Santosh Mishra, Green Energy Businessperson of the Year for Sandip Sali of Ampergia and Voltx Power and Excellence in Banking and Finance for Amardeep Sharma of Greenback Capital Ltd. (*PTI*)

# Brazil investigates Amazon wildfires that disrupt daily life, have fuelled political attacks

**GABRIELA SA PESSO**
■ Sao Paulo



Brazilian authorities are investigating whether a recent surge in wildfires in the Amazon rainforest have been set on purpose for political motives ahead of the second round of presidential elections later this month.

Fire counts across the biome, which have been near historic lows this year, have tripled since October 4, when Brazilians voted in the first round of national elections. Sen. Flavio Bolsonaro, the son of former President Jair Bolsonaro, won 47 per cent of the vote, while President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva received 45 per cent. The two will face off in an October 25 runoff. "The indications are that there has been a premeditated effort" to start the fires, Environment Minister Joao Paulo Capobianco told The Associated Press.

Capobianco and environmental enforcement officials flew over burned areas on Sunday and again on Wednesday. He said they observed fires in protected forest areas arranged in a distinct geometric pattern, suggesting they may have been deliberately set.

It's not clear who might have started the fires or what their motivations may be. The wildfires have particularly hit Amazonas and Para states over the past few days. Smoke has disrupted daily life in Manaus, the capital of Amazonas and the largest city in the Brazilian Amazon.

Public school classes were canceled and residents were urged to wear face masks.

Conservative politicians in Amazonas state have been the most vocal about the fires, according to monitoring by Barometro, a tool developed by Brazilian climate strategy agency FALA, part of the global Climate Action Against Disinformation coalition. The analysis examined 165 posts about fires and smoke in the state from 41 politicians, finding that nearly 55 per cent came from the right. Over the weeks, personal publications gave way to political disputes, with local politicians claiming credit for firefighting efforts or accusing authorities of failing to act. "The same issue serves simultaneously as a public health warning, an environmental policy agenda and a campaign tool," the report said.

The fires have also become a point of contention outside the Amazon, in an election campaign in which forest protection and climate change have received little attention. Deforestation in the Amazon soared under former President Bolsonaro, while Lula has brought it back down to the lowest in a decade. Flavio Bolsonaro has denied climate change but said he is an environmental defender, without offering details on protecting the Amazon or supporting forest financing. In speeches, he has called for modernizing environmental laws, which many environmentalists read as loosening them.

The Bolsonaros most popular allies — Nikolas Ferreira, a lawmaker from the state of Minas Gerais, and reelected Sao Paulo Gov. Tarcisio de Freitas, both from southeastern Brazil — cited wildfires last week to criticize Lula's Government. (*AP*)

The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | OCTOBER 16, 2026



# FlySakhi graduates its first cohort of women drone entrepreneurs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Hyderabad




Twenty-five rural women on Thursday completed the first cohort of FlySakhi — Drone Queens of Bharat and received their certificates at a Valedictory Session at TiHAN, IIT Hyderabad. Themed "Empowering Women Entrepreneurs through Agricultural Drone Technology", the programme trains rural women not merely as drone operators but as owners of rural drone-service enterprises.

FlySakhi is led by WCOOPEF and CNRI, with TiHAN-IIT Hyderabad as technology partner and Syngenta India Pvt. Ltd. as CSR partner. It brings together the cooperative movement, civil society, academia, industry, research institutions and development finance behind a single goal: placing women at the controls of India's agricultural transformation.

The Inaugural address was delivered by Dileep Shanghani, Chairman, World Cooperation Economic Forum. Dr. (Ms.) C Tara Satyavathi, Director General, ICAR-NIPHM (National Institute of Plant Health Management) and Director, ICAR-Indian Institute of Millets Research, was the Chief Guest. Meenal Maheshwari, CFO, Syngenta India, delivered the Presidential Address.

Sangeeta Dawar, Head of Business Sustainability & Corporate Affairs at Syngenta India, said, "At Syngenta, our vision is to contribute to a more sustainable and resilient agricultural ecosystem by empowering farming communities, strengthening rural livelihoods and promoting responsible agricultural practices. We believe that the future of agriculture depends not only on scientific innovation and access to modern solutions, but also on building knowledge, skills and awareness among the people who are at the heart of this sector. Our sustainability initiatives, including I RISE (Inculcating Rural India Skill Enhancement), I CLEAN (Inculcating Cleanliness, Learning, Education, Awareness and New Habits) and WeCare, reflect this commitment by addressing different aspects of rural development and community well-being. Together, these initiatives represent our belief that sustainable agriculture must go hand in hand with social progress and inclusive development. By working in partnership with communities and other stakeholders, we aim to create lasting impact on the ground, strengthen the capabilities of rural India and contribute to a future where agricultural progress translates into better opportunities and improved livelihoods."

The programme is a flagship activity of CSRNAM 2026, aligned with the Panch Pran and the vision of Viksit Bharat @2047. It commemorates the United Nations International Year of the Woman Farmer 2026.

Training covered drone operation, flight safety, multipurpose agricultural and rural applications, and the Drone-as-a-Service business model. Women carry a large and growing share of India's farm work, yet they rarely own the land, machinery or data that drive farm incomes. FlySakhi is designed to change that equation. It places a high-value, high-skill technology directly in the hands of rural women and builds the enterprise around them.

The programme works on three levels of empowerment: **Economic**: Each graduate can offer drone services to farmers, cooperatives and Farmer Producer Organisations (FPOs) on a fee-for-service basis. The bankable certificate opens the door to institutional credit for owning a drone.
**Social**: A woman drone pilot becomes a visible role model in her village. She changes perceptions of who can lead technology in agriculture.
**Institutional**: Graduates can be linked to cooperatives, Self-Help Groups and FPOs, so that drone assets and earnings stay within community-owned structures.

The trainees began on 5 October 2026 with virtual theory modules, followed by hands-on flight training at TiHAN. The model complements national efforts such as the Namo Drone Didi initiative, and adds a strong enterprise and cooperative dimension. The session opened with the ceremonial lamp-lighting. Santosh Reddy, Executive Officer, TiHAN, IIT Hyderabad, welcomed the gathering, and Shobha Yadav felicitated the guests and presented the FlySakhi journey. Dr Nirupam Mehrotra, Director, BIRD, NABARD, delivered the Distinguished Keynote Address online.

Distinguished addresses were delivered by Prof. Rajalakshmi, Head, TiHAN, IIT Hyderabad; Dr Sangeeta Dawar Mendiratta, Head - Sustainability & Corporate Affairs, Syngenta India; Vishwas Tripathi, Co-Chairman, CNRI, and Founder Chairman, Indo-Pacific Chambers of Commerce and Industry; Nguyen Thi Mai Chi, Head, Innovation Centre, Syngenta India; Chandrashekhar Ayyagaddi, Division Manager, Syngenta; and Dr Shankar Goenka, Head, Wow Green. The trainees shared their experience in an open interaction before the certificates were presented.

# Special Joint State Representative and Additional Director General's conference concludes at Guwahati

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Guwahati



The Joint State Representative & Additional Director General's Conference 2026 was held at Guwahati on 15 October 2026 under the aegis of the North Eastern Region Directorate of the National Cadet Corps (NCC). The Conference was chaired by the Raksha Rajya Mantri Sanjay Seth.

Among the State Government representatives, the conference was attended by Bishwajit Daimari, Minister of Sports & Youth Welfare, Govt of Assam, Pasang Dorjee Sona, Minister of Education, Govt of Arunachal Pradesh, Kishor Barman, Minister of Higher Education, Govt of Tripura, B Kalyan Chakravarthy, IAS, Additional Chief Secretary, Govt of Assam, K Bono Singh, IAS, Additional Secretary Education, Govt of Manipur, Ankur Bharali, Director, Department of Sports & Youth Welfare, Govt of Assam, P Marilyn R, Deputy Secretary Sports & Youth Resources, Govt of Mizoram and L Libemo Jami, Additional Director, Youth Resources & Sports, Govt of Nagaland.

The conference was attended by Lt Gen Virendra Vats, UYSM, SM, VSM, Director General NCC, along with the Additional Director Generals of NCC North Eastern Region and West Bengal & Sikkim Directorates, senior officials from the Ministry of Defence and senior representatives.

From the Ministry of Defence, the conference was attended by Dipti Mohil Chawla, Additional Secretary, MoD and Jitendar Kumar Mehan, Joint Secretary (Finance & AF), MoD.

In his address, the Raksha Rajya Mantri appreciated the active participation and constructive deliberations, noting that the Conference provided a useful platform to address State-specific issues and identify measures for further strengthening NCC in this strategically important region comprising West Bengal, Sikkim and the North Eastern States.

Highlighting NCC expansion as a key priority of the Government, the Raksha Rajya Mantri reiterated that under the visionary leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who himself was an exemplary NCC cadet, the Government has embarked upon an ambitious pan-India expansion to induct three lakh additional cadets. Quoting the Prime Minister that "The NCC is a movement that empowers India's Yuva Shakti, making our youth confident, disciplined, and dedicated to the nation", he urged State Governments to accord concurrence and extend necessary support so that benefits of expansion reach youth, particularly in areas with greater demand, with focus on meaningful character building, leadership and nation-building.

The Minister emphasised that NCC is a shared responsibility and called upon States to expeditiously address civilian manpower requirements and facilitate administrative arrangements, including appropriate institutional status for ADG NCC Directorates as Head of Department in the State.

He also discussed budgetary and financial support, particularly in respect of West Bengal, and expressed confidence that the State Government will extend requisite financial and administrative support commensurate with NCC's growing footprint, noting that investment in NCC is an investment in youth and in the future of the nation.

On training infrastructure, the Raksha Rajya Mantri stressed the significance of permanent and modern NCC Training Academies, especially in the North Eastern Region and other geographically challenging areas, to provide cadets opportunities in adventure, leadership, physical fitness and skill development, and encouraged States and NCC Directorates to work together to expedite such facilities.

He highlighted the integration of NCC with the education system through elective and credit-bearing courses as an important step towards mainstreaming NCC within the academic framework and urged States and educational institutions to take the initiative forward.

The Minister also lauded NCC's efforts towards promoting Nari Shakti through increasing participation of girl cadets and initiatives such as All Girls PRANGLA Trek, reflecting confidence, courage and leadership potential of young women, and noted that North Eastern Region, Sikkim and West Bengal have immense potential to become strong centres for empowering girl cadets through adventure, leadership and community engagement.

Concluding his address, he emphasised that strengthening NCC requires a whole-of-government and Centre-State partnership and requested that issues deliberated during the Conference be followed up with clear timelines and coordinated action by State Governments, DG NCC and Ministry of Defence, to ensure that every cadet emerges with greater confidence, discipline, skills and deeper sense of responsibility towards the nation, in keeping with NCC motto "Unity and Discipline" and the vision of Viksit Bharat.

# A7 GLOBAL PLATFORM TO REINVENT PAYMENTS MARKET

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Reflecting A7's international positioning and expanding the geography of settlements available to foreign clients, A7 International enables businesses and individuals to pay invoices with digital assets, while recipients receive a regular bank transfer. According to release, A7 has become one of the key players in the international settlements market. Founded in 2024 to serve the foreign economic activity of Russian businesses, it currently serves around 15,000 companies, processing 10+ trillion roubles in 2025 alone. The services A7 offered domestically sparked interest among businesses from other countries, prompting the company to come up with a new product for foreign clients. The launch of A7 International marks a new stage in A7's journey.

"We are presenting not just a new product in the lineup, but a new image of A7. We have adapted our service so that it can be used remotely from anywhere in the world. This is precisely the key demand of market participants today. They want to be able to transfer money around the world in a few clicks in the shortest possible time – directly from your smartphone, without lengthy paperwork, hidden fees, or unjustified holds on funds. And we are packaging this demand into a convenient and competitive form," said Chairman of Bank PSB Petr Fradkov. The mechanics of the service are simple: the client transfers USDT, and A7 arranges a bank transfer via SWIFT using the counterparty details specified in the invoice.

"The system operates as follows. AI analyzes the sender and beneficiary, jurisdictions, and key risk factors of transaction. Based on verification results, risk profile of payment is formed and the available options for processing it aredetermined. The system compares compliance requirements with capabilities of the existing payment infrastructure. After that, it recommends optimal payment route taking into account its cost, speed, reliability, and applicable restrictions," noted A7 CEO Ilan Shor.

# Univastu acquires assets of Cambium Networks ePMP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Pune

Univastu India Limited (NSE: UNIVASTU) on Thursday announced that its wholly owned UK subsidiary, Univastu UK Limited, has completed the acquisition of specified assets of Cambium Networks Limited (in administration) relating to the ePMP fixed wireless broadband and Enterprise Wi-Fi and switching businesses. The sale was completed under the final Business Sale Agreement with Cambium Networks Limited (in administration), acting by the Joint Administrators of RSM UK Restructuring Advisory LLP.

The acquisition completed on October 13, 2026 following execution of the Business Sale Agreement. It marks a significant step in Univastu's expansion into the global telecom technology market. Univastu will now work to establish a focused operating platform for the acquired businesses and develop a long-term plan for product development, customer support, supply and channel engagement.

The businesses serve internet service providers, telecom operators, enterprises and channel partners with connectivity products used across a range of markets. Univastu will operate the acquired business under the Cambium Networks brand, subject to the rights acquired under the transaction, preserving the name and identity recognized by customers and channel partners. Univastu's priority is to build a capable, focused operation and work with customers, employees and partners as it develops plans for product development, customer support, supply and channel engagement.

"Today marks an important step in Univastu's ambition to build a global telecom technology business," said Dr. Pradeep Khandagale, Chairman and Managing Director of Univastu India Limited. "Cambium's products have earned the trust of customers and partners over many years. We will work with them, listen carefully, and build a capable business for the long term." The completed acquisition adds global connectivity technology businesses to Univastu's existing infrastructure platform.

# Delhi's OOH Media Owners conduct meet




An insightful gathering of Delhi's OOH Media Owners at NCUI Auditorium Complex PIONEER PHOTO

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

An insightful gathering of Delhi's OOH Media Owners was held at NCUI Auditorium Complex to discuss the current landscape, challenges, and future opportunities in the sector.

Ankur Rastogi shared valuable perspectives on strengthening the marketing and positioning of OOH as one of the most impactful and cost-effective advertising mediums.

The symposium witnessed the presence of Mukesh Gupta, Pramod Bhandula, Sudhir Haryal, Dinesh Vasudeva, Mysa Ganesh, Ritesh Vasudeva, Rajesh Khanna, and Sarvesh Baliyan. The gathering saw a meaningful exchange of ideas towards building a stronger, more visible, and future-ready OOH industry.

# VFS Global opens its first visa application centre in Guwahati

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Guwahati



VFS Global, the global leader in trusted technology services, has announced the opening of a new visa application centre in Guwahati, reinforcing its commitment to expanding access to international mobility solutions across Northeast India. The centre was jointly inaugurated by Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma Chief Minister of Assam; Ajanta Neog, Minister for Tourism; Charan Boro, Minister for Transport; and Yummi Talwar, Chief Operating Officer, South Asia, VFS Global. The ceremony was attended by dignitaries from the diplomatic missions of Switzerland, Czech Republic, Italy, and France.

The new facility will process visa applications for 14 countries, including Austria, Cyprus, Czech Republic, Egypt, Estonia, France, Ireland, Italy, Japan, Latvia, Malta (D-Visa applications), Morocco, Switzerland and the United Kingdom.

The opening marks VFS Global's first Visa Application Centre in Assam and reflects the growing demand for international travel from Northeast India. Serving applicants from Assam, Arunachal Pradesh, Meghalaya, Manipur, Mizoram, Nagaland, Tripura and Sikkim, the centre strengthens regional access to visa services through a strategically located facility with strong air, rail and road connectivity. Its location in Guwahati, the commercial gateway to Northeast, positions it to support the region's expanding aspirations in tourism, education, business and global mobility.

Yummi Talwar, Chief Operating Officer - South Asia, VFS Global, said; "We are pleased to inaugurate our new Visa Application Centre in Guwahati, strengthening access to visa services for applicants across Assam and the wider Northeast. With growing aspirations around education, business, tourism and global mobility, reliable access to visa services is central to turning ambition into opportunity. We are grateful to the Government of Assam and our partner missions for their confidence in us. Through secure, technology-led processes and a commitment to service excellence, we will continue to offer an efficient and convenient visa application experience and make international travel simpler for every applicant we serve."

Himanta Biswa Sharma, CM of Assam, said; "As we move forward, our focus must remain on building stronger connections, creating opportunities for our young people, supporting businesses, and welcoming visitors from across the world. The inauguration of this visa application centre is an important step in that direction. It represents more than a new facility; it represents progress towards a more connected, accessible, and opportunity-driven Northeast. I congratulate VFS Global and everyone associated with this initiative. I am confident that this centre will make a meaningful contribution to people of Assam and Northeast region."

**PARADIP PORT AUTHORITY**
**ROADS & BUILDING DIVISION**
No.CE/R&B/ACCTS-21/26(Pt-I)/286,
Date: 12.10.2026
**e-TENDER CALL NOTICE**
Name of the work: **Providing Engineering cum Project Management Consultancy (PMC) services for the work "Improvement and strengthening of road by providing concrete overlay over existing bituminous pavement along with side drains from Administrative Building Exit Gate front to Hanuman Temple via Sub-station Square".** Estimated cost: **75.91 Crores**. Last Date & time of submission of Bid: 02.11.2026 at 17:30 Hrs. Refer our website for details: https://eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app
Sd/- Executive Engineer,
Roads & Building Division,
Paradip Port Authority
PPA/PR/33/2026-2027 dtd. 15.10.2026

# Gurugram festival returns for its third edition in Millenium City

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Gurugram




While a city may grow through business, buildings, and ambition, its soul is forged by the art it embraces and the traditions it keeps alive. Driven by this belief, the Gurugram Festival returns for its third edition from November 27-29, 2026, at Epicentre, Apparel House, Gurugram.

Building on two celebrated years, the three-day festival aims to make the arts a visible, accessible part of daily life in one of India's most dynamic urban hubs by bringing together classical music, dance, literature, and creative heritage to bridge generations, cultivate new audiences, and extend the experience of art far beyond the stage.

For the Gurugram Festival, its third edition marks another step towards creating a sustainable platform for artistic excellence, cultural exchange and community engagement. Through performances, workshops, masterclasses and conversations, the festival aims to make the arts more accessible while creating opportunities for audiences to engage more deeply with artists.

Vikram Dutta, Founder of Gurugram Festival, said, "The Gurugram Festival was founded on the belief that a city's identity is shaped as much by its cultural life as by its economic and urban growth. The warmth and engagement over our first two editions have inspired us to continue expanding this platform."

"With Season 3, we want to celebrate the masters who have devoted their lives to India's artistic traditions while opening doors for younger talent to find an audience. We hope the festival serves as a shared space where people gather to discover, learn, and experience the arts and where culture becomes an enduring part of Gurugram's story", he added.

The Gurugram Festival reflects a clear philosophy: a city's progress is measured not only by what it builds, but also by the cultural experiences it offers its residents. As Gurugram continues to evolve, the festival enriches civic life by uniting artists and audiences in an atmosphere of discovery, participation, and dialogue. Season 3 builds on the festival's foundational years, bringing classical traditions into the city's everyday conversation while creating new access points for younger generations.

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**Notice Inviting Tender**
www.verka.coop

**e- Tenders are hereby Invited for the purchase and supply of following items:-**

| Sr. No. | Name of Work/Item | Period/Tentative Qty |
|---|---|---|
| 1. | For Verka Ferozepur Dairy<br>Hiring of insulated milk tankers for transportation of milk from BMC's to Verka Ferozepur Dairy/MCC's (Ghallu, Jalalabad) on Annual rate contract **Capacity 10000 kgs** (single/double chamber). | Annual/05 No's |
| 2. | For Verka Hoshiarpur Dairy<br>e-Tender for the providing plant operators for operation of powder plant (02 no's) and CIP Operators (02). | - |
| 3. | For Verka Gurdaspur Dairy<br>a) Lifting of old used LDPE damaged polyfilm.<br>b) Supply, Installation and Commissioning of new main LT Panel capacity 2000 amp.<br>c) Supply, Installation and Commissioning of kheer cup filling and sealing machine (200 gm dia 95mm). | 01 No.<br>01 No.<br>01 No. |
| 4. | For Verka Ludhiana Dairy<br>a) Insurance of stock of milk,milk products, cattle feed, seeds, mineral feed supplements, semen, ghee, table butter, white butter, WMP, packing material, testing equipment, and any other stock against fire, burglary, special perils, earthquake and FST/STFI risks (storm, tempest, flood, inundation, hurricane , cyclone, Tornado), etc., for The Ludhiana district Co-operative milk producer's Union Ltd., its storage centres, sub-stores and chilling centres, i.e., MCC Raikot, MCC Machhiwara Sahib, MCC Bija and MCC Ramgarh Sardaran.<br>**b) Hiring of :-**<br>i. Insulated road milk tankers for transportation of milk from BMC/MCC/other milk unions/hired plants. Cap.10000 to12000 lt.approx. & Single portion.<br>ii. Vehicles (Tempo) for Cattle Feed/ Milk Products/Technical Services.<br>iii. Vehicles (Tempo) for transportation of Milk through Cans. | Annual Rate Contract<br><br>50 No's<br>06 No.'s<br>36 No.'s |
| 5. | For Verka Jalandhar Dairy<br>a) Steam coal having calorific value not less than 5500 kcal/kg.<br>b) Hiring of warehouse/store for storage of SMP/WMP bags.<br>c) Annual rate contract for lifting/sale of Paneer Whey.<br>d) Disposal of unserviceable scrap material (one time basis). | 1500 MT<br>Approx. 1800-2000 Mt<br>One Year<br>Annual/As per site |
| 6. | For Verka Amritsar Dairy<br>**Hiring of insulated:-**<br>a) Vehicle for supply of Fresh Milk and Milk Products at Patti & surrounding area.<br>b) Vehicle for supply of Fresh Milk and milk products at Local Route.<br>c) Single portion road milk tankers (capacity-10000 ltr.) for the transportation of Milk from BMC/MCC to Verka Amritsar Dairy. | <br>Two Years<br>Two Years<br>Two Years/10 No's |
| 7. | For Verka Cattle Feed Plant, Bhattian (Khanna)<br>i. Copper Sulphate<br>ii. Sodium Borate<br>iii. Potassium Iodide<br>iv. Beta Carotene<br>v. Zeolite<br>vi. Cobalt Sulphate<br>vii. Manganese Sulphate<br>viii. Ferrous Sulphate<br>ix. Formaldehyde Solution<br>x. By Pass | Annual/Qty. in MTs<br>2.5<br>6<br>1.2<br>1.5<br>25<br>2.5<br>2<br>6<br>50<br>175 (03 months) |

**NOTE:**
1. For complete details regarding above tender (NIT), please visit our website i.e. www.verka.coop & e Tendering portal i.e. **eproc.punjab.gov.in.**
2. Corrigendum, if any, will be uploaded on website only.

1018/12/2026-27/16241
**General Manager (Purchase)**

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# IDBI Bank shares drops nearly 8% after Fairfax deal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi




Shares of IDBI Bank ended nearly 8 per cent lower on Thursday after rallying sharply in the previous session as the Cabinet cleared Fairfax Financial's proposal to acquire a 60.72 per cent stake in the lender for about ₹53,000 crore.

The stock tanked 7.71 per cent to settle at ₹ 83.47 on the BSE. During the day, it dropped 8.72 per cent to ₹ 82.55. At the NSE, the stock dived 7.67 per cent to end at ₹ 83.45. The company's market valuation eroded by ₹7,494.43 crore to ₹89,750.30 crore. On Wednesday, shares of IDBI Bank surged 9 per cent before the announcement, adding ₹ 8,086 crore to its market valuation.

Canada's Fairfax Financial Holdings will acquire a 60.72 per cent stake in IDBI Bank for about ₹53,000 crore, in what would be the largest foreign investment in an Indian bank and a major milestone in the country's long-delayed banking privatisation drive.

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs approved Fairfax subsidiary M/s 10955230 Canada Inc as the strategic buyer for the government's 30.48 per cent stake (for about ₹26,620 crore) and state-run Life Insurance Corporation of India's (LIC) 30.24 per cent stake (for about ₹ 26,440 crore).

Canadian billionaire Prem Watsa-led Fairfax will pay Rs 81 per share, higher than the benchmark fair value of ₹75.99 determined by two independent valuation agencies, an official statement said on Wednesday.

The deal - the largest in the banking space - marks a major milestone in a long-delayed effort to privatise IDBI Bank and reduce state ownership of commercial enterprises. The sale process began in 2022 and faced a setback earlier this year when initial bids fell below the government's reserve price.

The transaction still needs approval from the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), which will conduct a "fit and proper" assessment, as well as the Competition Commission of India (CCI) and other statutory authorities.

# Jio says services, not tariff hikes, to drive revenue



Jio Platforms plans to raise revenue per customer mainly by selling more services rather than lifting tariffs, though it keeps the option of higher prices, Managing Director Akash Ambani said on Thursday, days before the Reliance Industries unit opens what would be India's largest initial public offering. "We always have the ability to take up prices," Ambani told a press conference in Mumbai, but the company would rather give customers more services and charge for them than rely on price per gigabyte as its main lever.

Asked whether a tariff increase was coming, he gave no timeline. He said telecom spending per user as a share of India's per-capita income had roughly halved to about 1 per cent since Jio's 2016 launch, which he called headroom. Chief Executive Pankaj Pawar said tariffs were only one of several levers. Ambani said Jio charges about ₹4.9 per gigabyte against an industry average of ₹7.5, with customers using 43.7 GB a month.

"We expect a $1.4-trillion digital economy by FY31; we will take a huge market share of this," Ambani said, naming mobile, home broadband and enterprise and international services as the growth engines.

He said Jio carries more than 60 per cent of India's wireless data traffic. New services outside Jio's licensed telecom business, such as a voice-AI feature announced at Reliance's annual meeting, could push its EBITDA margin above the current level. The margin was 53.3 per cent in April-June, up from about 50 per cent three years ago, he added. On overseas expansion, Ambani said Jio would offer its in-house network technology to foreign operators as a managed-service partner, not by selling hardware or software licences, and without heavy capital spending. (*PTI*)

# India-US trade deal first tranche finalised, legal drafting underway: Piyush Goyal

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi



Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Thursday said the first tranche of the proposed India-US trade agreement has been finalised and is undergoing legal drafting, signalling progress in negotiations between the two countries.

The government hopes to complete the process soon, with implementation contingent on India securing a competitive advantage for its exporters.

"The first tranche has been finalised and is going through the final legal drafting. We hope to finalise it soon and operationalise it once we get a competitive advantage over our peer countries," Goyal said. Negotiations between India and the United States on the proposed bilateral trade agreement are progressing positively, with discussions in a favourable zone, according to Commerce Ministry officials.

However, the agreement will be signed only after both sides reach an understanding on the overall tariff structure and India secures preferential market access for its exporters. "The negotiations are in the right direction, in a good zone.

The deal has to be signed when the overall tariff structure is agreed upon. India has to get preferential market access," officials said. The remarks highlight New Delhi's emphasis on ensuring that the agreement delivers tangible benefits to Indian businesses and enables domestic exporters to compete effectively in the US market. Tariff arrangements and the relative competitiveness of Indian goods are expected to remain central to the final negotiations. India and the US announced a framework for an interim trade deal in February.

However, the agreement has yet to be implemented as both sides continue working towards finalising its terms.

For India, securing preferential access to the American market is a key objective, particularly as global trade policies and tariff regimes continue to evolve. New Delhi is seeking terms that would place Indian exporters on a competitive footing with suppliers from other countries.

The final tariff structure is likely to play a decisive role in determining the timeline for signing and implementing the agreement.

While the completion of legal drafting marks progress on the first tranche, the deal's operationalisation will depend on the finalisation of mutually acceptable terms. The proposed agreement could have significant implications for bilateral trade flows, export opportunities and market access across multiple sectors.

It also forms part of India's broader efforts to diversify export markets, strengthen trade ties with major economies and expand its presence in global commerce.

Although the latest remarks indicate progress in discussions with Washington, the final outcome will depend on the terms agreed upon by both countries and the extent to which the arrangement improves the competitive position of Indian exporters in the US market.



# Mahindra enters the CNG race with XUV 3XO ZNG

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Mumbai

Mahindra & Mahindra launched the XUV 3XO ZNG, its first mainstream CNG passenger vehicle, at a starting price of ₹9.99 lakh (ex-showroom). Test drives commenced today, with bookings and deliveries opening October 20.

The launch brings the SUV specialist into a segment that has become one of Indian motoring's biggest growth stories. CNG's share of passenger vehicle sales has more than tripled in five years — from 6.3 per cent in FY2020 to 19.5 per cent in FY2025, according to SIAM data. In FY2025, CNG cars outsold diesel cars for the first time — 787,724 units to 736,508 — on Vahan registrations. Separately, FADA data shows CNG's share of passenger vehicle retail sales rising from 19.60 per cent in FY2025 to 21.98 per cent in FY2026, second only to petrol.

Maruti Suzuki has been the segment's biggest beneficiary. The country's largest carmaker sold about 6.2 lakh CNG vehicles in FY2025 — up 28 per cent year on year — meaning one in every three Marutis sold ran on gas, compared with 12 per cent of its sales in FY2021.

Volumes rose further to 7.46 lakh units in FY2026, and Maruti holds roughly 70 per cent of the CNG passenger vehicle market.

CNG has also become a major growth driver for Tata Motors. Its CNG volumes jumped 50 per cent to 139,218 units in FY2025, accounting for a quarter of its sales — up from 16 per cent in FY2024 and 8 per cent in FY2023.

In the 12 months to September 2026, its first year as a demerged passenger vehicle company, Tata sold over 2.03 lakh CNG vehicles, or 27 per cent of its volumes. Mahindra claims to have engineered the new 3XO ZNG for performance and driving dynamics, an aspect hitherto ignored on CNG vehicles. The company claims the XUV 3XO ZNG's 1.2-litre turbocharged engine delivers identical 82 kW power and 200 Nm torque — best-in-class among CNG passenger vehicles in India in both CNG and petrol modes, with certified efficiency of 24.7 km/kg.

Twin cylinders packaged under the boot floor preserve a flat loading floor and 270 litres of luggage space, addressing the boot-space trade-off that comes with conventional CNG installations. Six airbags and ESC are standard across variants; prices top out at ₹12.27 lakh.

# FM holds bilateral talks with UK, Swiss, Japanese counterparts in Bangkok

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman held a series of bilateral meetings with her counterparts from the UK, Switzerland and Japan in Bangkok and discussed ways to deepen financial and economic cooperation.

In her meeting with UK Chancellor of the Exchequer John Healey on the sidelines of the World Bank-IMF annual meetings, Sitharaman discussed the successful conclusion of the fourth India-UK Financial Markets Dialogue, fintech meetings and associated India-UK Financial Partnership (IUKFP) meetings, building on the outcomes of the previous Economic and Financial Dialogue (EFD).

Both sides agreed to hold the next EFD in December 2026, the finance ministry said in a post on X. Sitharaman also reaffirmed India's commitment to working closely with the UK on shared priorities and ensuring a constructive and inclusive G20 process.

In a separate meeting with Swiss Federal Councillor and Head of the Federal Department of Finance Karin Keller-Sutter, the two sides discussed the India-EFTA Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement (TEPA) and the early conclusion of a mutually beneficial India-Switzerland Bilateral Investment Treaty (BIT).

Sitharaman highlighted India's strong macroeconomic fundamentals, supported by fiscal discipline, robust domestic demand and infrastructure modernisation, as offering significant opportunities for Swiss investors. The two sides also explored investment opportunities through the National Investment and Infrastructure Fund (NIIF) and GIFT City.

Cooperation in cross-border digital payments, FinTech, regulatory innovation and AI in financial services also featured in the discussions, the ministry said in another post.

During her meeting with Japanese Finance Minister Satsuki Katayama, Sitharaman reviewed the India-Japan Strategic Global Partnership and welcomed Japan's commitment to facilitate JPY 10 trillion in private investment into India.

She handed over a written invitation for a visit by the Japanese side to India in 2027 to mark the 75th anniversary of diplomatic relations through high-level engagements.

"FM Smt. @nsitharaman highlighted that a huge chunk of the India-Japan Fund corpus has been deployed in clean energy, electric mobility, critical minerals and resilient supply chains.

# Rupee gains for 5th straight session, closes at 94.99

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Mumbai



The rupee logged the fifth straight session of gains on Thursday, appreciating 12 paise to close at 94.99 (provisional) against the US dollar, supported by the ongoing impact of the Reserve Bank of India's structural forex interventions.

Market participants attributed the rupee's continued appreciation to central bank intervention and the unwinding of long dollar positions. However, ongoing external macroeconomic pressures are likely to temper further gains, they said.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 94.95 against the American currency. In intraday trade, it touched a high of 94.86 and a low of 95.11 and settled at 95.05 (provisional) against the greenback, registering a gain of 12 paise from its previous close.

On Wednesday, the rupee appreciated 19 paise to close at 95.17 against the US dollar. In the last five sessions, the rupee has gained 183 paise against the US dollar. "The Indian rupee extended its winning streak to a fifth consecutive session, supported by easing crude oil prices, the unwinding of dollar long positions, and strong domestic risk appetite.

**SBI STATE BANK OF INDIA** E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE

HOME LOAN CENTRE/RACPC -2, RAMA COMPLEX, SOHNA ROAD, BADSHAHPUR, GURUGRAM-122016

**APPENDIX II-A [SEE PROVISO TO RULE 6(2)]**
**SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF MOVABLE PROPERTIES**

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Movable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with Proviso to Rule 6(2) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. Notice is hereby given to the Public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described movable property hypothecated/charged to the secured Creditor, the Physical Possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer State Bank of India, the secured Creditor, will be **sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "Whatever there is" basis on 30.10.2026** (mention date of the sale), for recovery of below mentioned amounts due to the secured creditor from the below mentioned Borrowers. The reserve price and the earnest money deposit will be as mentioned against each Borrowers and Asset Details. **Date/Time of E-Auction on 30/10/2026 from 10:00 AM to 05:00 PM with unlimited extension of 10 minute each. Last Date of EMD Deposit on or before 29.10.2026 upto 04:00 PM.**

| S. No. | Name of the Borrower | Total Outstanding | Vehicle Description | Reserve Price (Rs.) (below which property could not be sold) / Earnest Money (EMD) 10% of the Reserve Price / Bid Increment Amount | Name of Authorised Officer & Contact Person |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1. | Mr. Pramod Janki Pandey, S/o Sh. Janki Pandey J-115/54, Sarup Garden Palam Vihar-I, Bajghera P.O. Carterpuri, Gurugram | Rs.20,07,080/- Plus Interest w.e.f. 07/04/2026 with further interest and incidental expenses, costs, charges etc. thereon | Make & Model: Hyundai - Creta Registration Number: HR26GA1512 Engine No.: D4FASM565190 Chassis No.: MALPC813MSM298446 | ₹ 14,25,000.00 / ₹ 1,42,500.00 / ₹ 1,000.00 / *GST Upto 18% | Sh. Sunil Kumar Duseja (Chief Manager) HLC-2, Gurugram / Mr. Praveen Nagar (R.A.) Mobile: 9813314646 |

*Applicable GST Upto 18% is payable by the successful bidder on the final bid amount. The Vehicle are available for inspection during banking hours please contact: **Mr. Praveen Nagar, Mob: 9813314646, (Resolution Agent).** For detailed terms and conditions of the sale and Live Auction, please refer to the link **"https://baanknet.com".** For Asset Details, please refer portal **"https://baanknet.com".** The bidders are required to submit acceptance of the terms & conditions and modalities of e-auction adopted by the service provider before participating in the e-auction. The payment of all statutory/non-statutory dues, taxes, rates, assessments, charges, fees etc., owing to anybody shall be the sole responsibility of successful bidder only.

**Date: 15.10.2026 Place: Gurugram** Authorized Officer, State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre/RACPC-2, Gurugram

**PUBLIC NOTICE**

Notice is hereby given to the public at large on behalf of my clients, (1) Reena Arora W/o Shiv Kumar Arora, (2) Rijul Arora S/o Shiv Kumar Arora and (3) Lakshay Arora S/o Shiv Kumar Arora all residing at E-292, 3rd Floor, Ramesh Nagar, New Delhi 110015, that the No Objection Certificate (NOC) dated 28.11.2023, issued by my clients in favor of Shiv Kumar Arora residing at E-292, 3rd Floor, Ramesh Nagar, New Delhi-110015, for the purpose of sale of the property bearing no. C-31, Okhla Industrial Area, Phase-1, New Delhi, stands cancelled and revoked with immediate effect.

The public is hereby cautioned and advised not to enter into any transactions including purchase, sale, lease, mortgage, gift, or transfer of any right in the said property based on the aforementioned NOC.

Any person dealing with the said Sh. Shiv Kumar Arora or any other person relying upon the cancelled NOC shall do so at their own risk, cost and consequences. My clients shall not be held liable or responsible for any such transactions, claims or damages arising therefrom.

**J. J. Tyagi (Advocate) Ch No. T-31, Tehsil Lane, Lawyer's Chambers, Tis Hazari court, Delhi-110054**

**हाईकोर्ट इलाहाबाद लखनऊ बेन्च, लखनऊ**

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विदित हो कि आप ऊपर लिखे दिनांक पर या उससे पहले स्वयं अथवा किसी एडवोकेट या ऐसे व्यक्ति द्वारा जो आपकी ओर से कार्य करने के लिए कानूनन अधिकृत हो उपस्थित न होंगे तो उस प्रार्थना–पत्र की सुनवाई और निर्णय आपकी अनुपस्थिति में हो जायेंगें। आपको सूचित किया जाता है किसी मौलिक डिग्री से जो प्रथम अपील होती है उनसे यदि अपील सरसरी तौर से समाप्त हो जाये तो उसके दोनों पक्ष वालों की एक पत्र पुस्तिका (पेपर बुक) तैयार करनी होती है। इसलिए आवश्यकता इस बात की है नियमावली में दिये गये समय के भीतर कागजी अनुवाद और छपाई के लिये प्रार्थना–पत्र आ जाये और अनुमति व्यय भी जमा हो जाये। मेरे हस्ताक्षर और न्यायालय की मोहर से आज दिनांक 01... माह..10 सन् 2026 को जारी किया गया।
Mahendra Pratap Singh के एडवोकेट
**तिथि 30/9/26 डिप्टी रजिस्ट्रार इलाहाबाद/लखनऊ**
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दिनांक : 12.10.2026

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| क्रमांक | कार्य का नाम | कार्य की लागत रू० (लाख में) |
|---|---|---|
| 1. | AMC of street lights and high mast network at IA. Talanagri for 03 years. | 67.23 |

निविदा दिनांक 16.09.2026 को 11:00 बजे से दिनांक 05.11.2026 को 18:00 बजे तक अपलोड की जा सकती है, जिसे दिनांक 06.11.2026 को 11:00 बजे या इसके पश्चात् खोली जायेगा। निविदादाताओं द्वारा अपलोड शपथ पत्रों की मूल प्रतियों निविदा खोलने के बाद 03 कार्य दिवस में पंजीकृत डाक/व्यक्तिगत रुप से कार्यालय में जमा की जा सकती है।
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क्रमांक 497/यांत्रिकी/पविनि/26 दिनांक: 15.10.2026

**निविदा सूचना 355/2026_STDC_543640_1**

मध्यप्रदेश राज्य पर्यटन विकास निगम भोपाल द्वारा निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु ऑनलाइन (Online) निविदा प्रपत्र APPENDIX 2.10 पर म.प्र. लोक निर्माण विभाग में उपयुक्त श्रेणी में पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से आमंत्रित की जाती है। **कार्य का नाम:-** मां शारदा माता मंदिर मैहर जिला मैहर में मां शारदा लोक के एकीकृत विकास कार्य बाहरी विद्युतीकरण सहित। (24 माह)। कार्य की अनुमानित लागत राशि रु. 3101.54 लाख
वेबसाइट पर ऑनलाइन भुगतान कर निविदा प्रपत्र (टेण्डर डाक्युमेंट) वेबसाइट के माध्यम से क्रय किये जा सकते है। निविदा प्रपत्र ऑनलाइन क्रय करने की **अंतिम तिथि 06.11.2026 समय सायं 05:00 बजे तक** निर्धारित है। कार्य का विस्तृत विवरण वेबसाइट **https://mptenders.gov.in** पर दिनांक 19.10.2026 से देखा जा सकता है।
म.प्र. माध्यम/128634/2026 कार्यपालन यंत्री

**मध्यप्रदेश पुलिस आवास एवं अधोसंरचना विकास निगम**
कार्यालय परियोजना यंत्री, ग्वालियर, संभाग ग्वालियर
ई-मेल : pe.policehousinggwa@mp.gov.in

**प्रेस विज्ञप्ति**

मध्यप्रदेश पुलिस आवास एवं अधोसंरचना विकास निगम, ग्वालियर, संभाग ग्वालियर द्वारा निविदा क्रमांक 17/2026-27 ऑनलाइन निविदा क्रमांक - 2026_MPPHC_543250_1, 2026_MPPHC_543251_1 2026_MPPHC_543252_1, ऑनलाइन निविदा क्रमांक- आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा प्रपत्र **दिनांक 11.11.2026 तक** ऑनलाइन खरीदे जा सकते हैं। विस्तृत निविदा सूचना एवं अन्य विवरण **Portal : https://www.mptenders.gov.in** पर देखे जा सकते हैं।
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The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | OCTOBER 16, 2026



# SC seeks Centre's reply on police-media interaction

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday sought responses from the Centre and others on a plea seeking guidelines governing how police and law-enforcement authorities interact with journalists during protests and crowd-control operations.

The apex court was hearing a plea which claimed that several journalists, including women media professionals, were assaulted and treated badly by the police while covering the protests in Delhi against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. "We would like to lay down guidelines," a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi observed after senior advocate Indira Jaising, appearing for the petitioner, said there has to be a national protocol on this.

The bench directed that no coercive action be taken against a woman journalist, against whom a case has been filed by a Delhi Police officer alleging casteist remarks and public humiliation against him during a protest near Jantar Mantar here. Jaising argued that the woman journalist was molested by a police officer, but no FIR has been lodged to date on her complaint.

The bench observed that the allegations in the woman journalist's complaint were "very serious". It asked the police to examine the complaint and complete its inquiry. Jaising urged the bench to direct that no more FIRs be registered against women journalists. "Even in



war zones in Israel and Palestine, journalists go there, and nobody stops them. Here, they are stopping journalists from going to Jantar Mantar," she said, adding that journalists have a right to report. Solicitor General Tushar Mehta told the bench, "The difficulty is that, in the present era of digital technology, anyone having a mobile is a journalist."

"Our experience is that there are several people who say they are freelance journalists. What is going on is reel-making in the protests.

"The problem is we don't know who is a reel-maker and who is an independent journalist," the top law officer said. Jaising argued that several women journalists, who were performing their duties, were allegedly pushed and assaulted, including by male police officers, during the protests. She urged the apex court to constitute an independent committee to look into the complaints of women journalists.

The bench observed that the committee could have predominantly or exclusively women members, such as former judges or retired IPS officers. Jaising, who said she could suggest names for the committee, told the bench that she would submit a list of complaints by women journalists in a sealed cover.

"Before this court, every voice is valuable, and everyone will be heard irrespective of numbers," the bench observed. Jaising argued that the police cannot investigate themselves and that an independent committee must examine the complaints made by female journalists covering the protests.

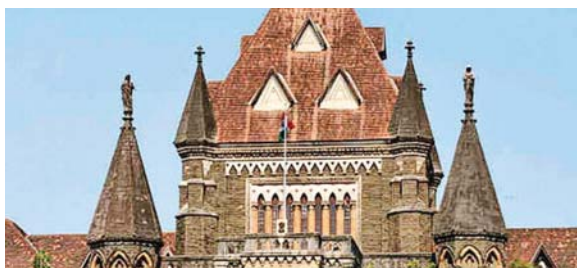
The bench issued notice on the plea seeking responses from the Centre and the Delhi Police. One of the advocates told the apex court that the police have seized electronic devices of several journalists who were covering the protests. Another advocate claimed that a large number of women protestors were treated badly by the police.

"Allow me to file my response," Mehta said.

After the top court asked the police not to take any coercive action against the woman journalist, senior advocate Gaurav Bhatia, appearing for some other petitioners, urged the bench to also consider the case of a pregnant woman journalist, who, he said, was allegedly pushed by Congress leader Rahul Gandhi in the apex court premises during the October 12 march.

## Order Order

### No firecrackers on roads all year, says Bombay HC



Ahead of the Diwali festival, the Bombay High Court on Thursday said its order banning the bursting of firecrackers on public roads and streets will be applicable throughout the year. A bench of Justices G S Kulkarni and Neela Gokhale said the "toxic pollution" from firecrackers affects every person, especially senior citizens and children, and the air pollution increases after Diwali.

During the Ganesh Chaturthi festival last month, the bench had ordered a complete ban on bursting firecrackers on public roads, noting that it causes not only air pollution but also noise pollution. The court had then taken suo motu (on its own) cognisance of the issue of noise pollution during festivals. On Thursday, the bench remarked that the Government and other authorities seemed to have no control over firecrackers.

"There is a state of lawlessness. We are all bound by the Constitution, and the rights of citizens are paramount. The problem is the non-following of law," the court said. The bench said its earlier order banning firecrackers on public roads would apply throughout the year and for all festivals, noting that this would meet the ends of justice. The court said the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) and the Maharashtra Pollution Control Board (MPCB) shall issue appropriate notices stating that the "burning of firecrackers at all public places, namely streets, lanes, and footpaths, shall not be permitted." (*PTI*)

### CMRL case: BJP welcomes HC order, CPI(M) to fight on



The BJP and Congress MLA Mathew Kuzhalnadan welcomed the Kerala High Court order dismissing pleas by former Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan and his kin to challenge the order registering an FIR against him in the alleged CMRL bribery case.

The CPI(M), on the other hand, claimed that the case against Vijayan, his daughter Veena T and her husband P A Mohamed Riyas was false and politically motivated and "a planned move" by the BJP and UDF to attack them and the Left party. Meanwhile, state Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala said the High Court order was not a setback to the State Government, as it acted in accordance with the law, not out of any political vendetta. After the High Court denied permission to Vijayan, Veena and Riyas to file an appeal challenging a single judge order directing the VACB to lodge an FIR against them, BJP leader Shone George told reporters that if the former CM "has a shred of shame" he should resign from the post of opposition leader in the State Assembly.

George said that the State Government cannot help Viayan any more than it already has from the time it received a letter from the Enforcement Directorate (ED) to register an FIR under the anti-graft law against the Marxist veteran and his family members. CPI(M) state secretary MV Govindan told reporters that the matter would be effectively dealt with politically and legally after examining the judgement. He also said the State Government should have filed an appeal against the single-judge order instead of implementing it immediately. He claimed that the High Court did not allow the Marxist veteran and his kin to file an appeal as an FIR had already been lodged by the Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (VACB). The CPI(M) state secretary termed the vigilance case against Vijayan and others as a planned move of the ED and the UDF Government to attack the CPI(M) veteran and Riyas and, through them, the left party. (*PTI*)

# Woman can face gangrape charge: Delhi HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



The Delhi High Court on Thursday held that under the criminal law, a woman can be charged with the offence of gang rape even if she herself has not committed the physical act but facilitated the victim's rape.

Justice Anup Jairam Bhambhani passed the judgment while dismissing a plea challenging the framing of charges against a woman accused of allegedly forcing her minor daughter to have sexual relations with a co-accused. "... this court is of the view that there is no basis to hold that a woman cannot be charged with the offence of gang rape under section 376D IPC and section 70 BNS.

The query posed in the present judgment is answered accordingly," the High Court said. The court was answering a question which arose for its consideration -- "Can a 'woman' be charged with the offence of 'gang rape' under section 376D IPC/section 70 BNS?"

According to Section 70 (gang rape) of Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, "where a woman is raped by one or more persons constituting a group or acting in furtherance of a common intention, each of those persons shall be deemed to have committed the offence of rape and shall be punished with rigorous imprisonment for a term which shall not be less than twenty years, but which may extend to imprisonment for life which shall mean imprisonment for the remainder of that person's natural life, and with fine".

Dealing with the interpretation of Section 70 BNS, Justice Bhambhani said in the opinion of this court, the use of the phrase "deemed to have committed the offence of rape" is clearly reflective of the legislative intent that, for being liable to be charged with the offence of 'gang rape', every person who constitutes a group or acts in furtherance of a common intention need not have individually committed the offence of rape.

The court clarified that its ruling does not mean a woman acting alone can be charged with gang rape. It also said it was not expressing any opinion on whether the word "man" in the post-2013 section 375 IPC or section 63 BNS is gender-neutral or not. The case arose from an FIR registered at Delhi's Bhalswa Dairy police station in July 2024.

According to the prosecution's case, the minor girl alleged that her mother threatened her and forced her to have sexual relations with the other accused. She also alleged that the assaults took place repeatedly between December 2023 and July 2024. The victim said that when she was threatened again by her mother to have sexual relations with the other accused, she left her home in July 2024.

# J&K High Court bans motorboats on Dal Lake



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Srinagar

The High Court of Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh has banned fuel-powered motorboats and jet skis from being plied on Dal Lake till further order.

A division bench comprising Chief Justice Pushpendra Singh Bhati and Justice Rajesh Sekhri on Wednesday issued the order on a petition filed by Mohammad Rafiq Mir.

"In the larger interest of justice, taking a comprehensive view of the submissions made, it is directed that the respondent authorities LCMA, Tourism, and Police shall ensure that no motor boat, whether it be a shikara motorboat or Jet Ski which operates by fuel, is operated in the Dal Lake until further orders," the bench said in the order.

The court also directed that any violation of the order will be seen as contempt of court.

"Therefore the officers concerned shall take a strict view by restricting and prohibiting such operations," the order read. The bench observed that the court is convinced that at a time when lake systems have become a growing concern for civilisation, steps are being taken to exclude activities which would cause pollution. "It would be important that whatever policy is framed is more reasonable while balancing tourism activities, pollution, as well as the uniformity between the players involved," it said.

The bench observed that solar boats and electric boats could be a solution to strike a balance between the needs of tour operators and sustenance of lakes.

Such boats as may be used for emergency services, law and order, disaster management, and safety will be exempted from this order, the court said. The Government was earlier directed to submit a comprehensive policy for motorised boats.

"(Mohsin) Qadri (senior additional advocate general) shall also explore and bring it before this court whether complete motorisation can be substituted by solarised e-engines," the bench said and listed the case for next hearing on October 30.

# Kolkata court restrains Mahua Moitra from defaming chief secretary

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kolkata



A Kolkata court has restrained Mamata AITC MP Mahua Moitra from making "any defamatory statement" against West Bengal Chief Secretary Manoj Agarwal after he complained that she made unsubstantiated allegations against him in connection with SIR.

The Civil Judge, Senior Division, 1st Court, Alipore, on Wednesday also directed the Krishnanagar MP to delete her social media posts against Agarwal related to the special intensive revision of electoral rolls and the conduct of this year's West Bengal assembly elections within 24 hours of receiving the order.

The court, however, clarified that this order will not "restrain fair criticism of the SIR or of any official decision".

In an ex parte interim order, the court restrained Moitra from publishing, posting, or repeating "any defamatory statement" against Agarwal, including any statement connected to two posts in question which she allegedly made on her X on October 3 and 6. Moitra, however, said on Thursday she will file a vacating application to reinforce her rights. The judge directed the MP to delete the posts from her social media handle within 24 hours of receiving the order, including receipt by e-mail.

The court directed that notice be issued to Moitra to show cause why the interim order should not continue until the disposal of Agarwal's application.

The court said the interim order will remain in force until January 5, 2027, when it will hear the matter again.

Permitting Moitra to file her written objection with all material she relies upon, the judge further directed that the MP may apply under the relevant rules for discharge, variation, or setting aside of this order.

# Ex-judges' panel hears testimonies of SIR-deleted voters

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

A panel of retired judges of the Supreme Court and high courts on Thursday heard accounts of people whose names have been deleted from electoral rolls following the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise undertaken across the country.

The panel, comprising retired Supreme Court judge A K Patnaik, retired Delhi High Court judge Rekha Sharma and retired Patna High Court judge Anjana Prakash, attended a public hearing of the Independent Commission on SIR constituted by the Lawyers Association for Constitution (LAFC). Actor and activist Prakash Raj also witnessed the hearing.

Former Supreme Court judge Justice Madan B Lokur, who was heading the commission, could not attend the first public hearing of the panel.

The LAFC had earlier set up a five-member commission, headed by Justice Lokur, to examine the constitutional and statutory validity, methodology and overall impact of the Election Commission's electoral roll revision exercise.



The hearing, held at Jawahar Bhawan in the national capital, heard accounts from people affected by the exercise in West Bengal, Delhi, Telangana, Bihar and Rajasthan. The panel first heard presentations on the impact of the SIR exercise on electoral rolls in various states before listening to testimonies from affected people, who took an oath in the name of God.

Among those who deposed before the commission was former West Bengal MP Tarun Mondal, whose name was deleted from the electoral roll following the revision.

"My name was struck out from the electoral list of West Bengal in this SIR process. I did apply, and the enrolment form was filled out by the entire family and me; finally, after their adjudications by the ELOs, etc., they disqualified me," he said.

Mondal, a doctor and resident of the South Howrah assembly constituency, said his name had previously been registered under Booth Number 279 but was removed during the latest revision. A resident of Delhi's Mangolpuri area, Kanta Prasad, told the panel that his name was deleted after the Election Commission declared him dead.

# Delhi HC pulls up ASI, MCD over illegal construction

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi




The Delhi High Court has pulled up the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), MCD and Delhi Police for overlooking unauthorised construction within the regulated area of the protected Tomb of Raushanara.

The court noted that unauthorised construction proceeded despite statutory restrictions and a judicial order restraining further construction. It directed the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) commissioner, special CP of Delhi Police and ASI director to file their personal affidavits disclosing the names of officials responsible for overlooking the unauthorised construction.

"The respondents, in our opinion, are free to take such steps in accordance with law that are permissible and provided. "However, we expect the highest officers of the MCD, the ASI and that of Delhi Police to file their respective personal affidavits, thereby disclosing the names of the senior officers who are responsible for the laches in overlooking such a serious default on the part of the private respondent in carrying out and continuing the unauthorised construction in absence of there being any sanction/ approval from the competent authority, that is, the ASI," a bench of Acting Chief Justice Nitin Wasudeo Sambre and Justice Sanjay Sharma said.

The high court, in its October 9 order, observed that the conduct of officials enabled the owner of the property to complete the unauthorised construction in the regulated area of the Tomb of Raushanara and the Barahdari.

It noted that though ASI has assured that action will be taken, there is neither sensitivity nor determination. Similarly, "too callous an approach and attitude" can be noticed on the part of the officials of the MCD, it said.

The court heard a plea by Manish Grover concerning unauthorised construction at a property on Singh Sahab Road in Shakti Nagar.

It noted that the ASI had issued a work-stop notice to the property owner on February 15, 2024, after finding that construction was being carried out in the regulated area of the protected monument. A police complaint was also lodged.

Thereafter, on April 10, 2024, the ASI official wrote to the MCD and the DCP of North West district, requesting immediate steps to halt and remove the unauthorised construction.

# 2020 Delhi riots: 5 acquitted, police probe questioned

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi




A Delhi court has acquitted five men accused of rioting and attempting to murder a man during the 2020 north-east Delhi riots, saying the investigating agency appeared to have tried to "fill the lacuna" in the case and failed to establish their presence at the spot where the victim was injured.

Additional Sessions Judge Sameer Bajpai was hearing a case against five men — Raj Kumar, Deepak Tomar, Gurmeet Singh, Gaurav and Vikram — accused of rioting, rioting with deadly weapons, unlawful assembly, attempt to murder and common intention under the IPC. The proceedings against Vikram had already been abated by the court on July 15 after his death.

In an order dated October 14, the court said, "The court must take note of the fact that the FIR in the present case was registered three days after the incident... surprisingly, the statements of Head Constables Sonu and Rafiq were recorded at a much later stage, which shows that the investigating agency tried to fill the lacuna in order to make out a case and resolve the same."

The court said the prosecution's case rested primarily on the identification of the accused through CCTV footage and photographs, which constituted weak evidence, particularly as the police witness was not previously acquainted with them.

The Pioneer
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# PM meets Asian Games medal winners; lauds performance

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi











Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday met India's Asian Games medal-winners, including the gold-winning men's and women's cricket teams, at the Major Dhyan Chand Stadium here and said the country is not just becoming a stronger force in terms of performance but also evolving into a "credible host" for major international events.

The PM posed for pictures with the medal winners and received memorabilia ranging from signed jerseys to a bow from 17-year-old recurve archer Kumkum Mohod, who won two gold medals (individual and women's team) and a silver (mixed team).

The contingent was accompanied by top officials of their respective governing bodies, including International Cricket Council Chairman Jay Shah and Indian Olympic Association (IOA) President P T Usha, among others.

"You have made 140 crore Indians proud. The biggest success is to make the Tricolour fly high. That's why your success is not just yours, but it belongs to crores of our countrymen. I congratulate you on behalf of the entire country," the PM said in his address to the medal winners.

"India is emerging in establishing itself as a credible and hospitable country for international sports events. We are bidding for the 2036 Olympics, and it is our resolve that we will host the games," he asserted.

India won 85 medals at the Asian Games, including 21 gold. The count was lower than the 106 medals achieved in the previous edition in Hangzhou, but the performance of India's Games debutants was heartening as they claimed 41 medals for the country.

"I especially want to congratulate our women athletes; they contributed 38 medals to our tally, and 11 of those medals were gold," Modi said, lauding the cricket teams, the hockey teams and the performance of archers, who won five gold medals.

> YOU HAVE MADE 140 CRORE INDIANS PROUD. THE BIGGEST SUCCESS IS TO MAKE THE TRICOLOUR FLY HIGH
> — PM NARENDRA MODI

"The women's hockey team ended a 44-year wait with its gold medal; it is highly appreciable," he added. The entire men's T20 team led by Shreyas Iyer, which has a match against the West Indies in Bengaluru on Saturday, was in attendance, along with the women's team, which is due to take on Zimbabwe in a T20 in Raipur on Friday.

Harmanpreet Kaur, who captained the side to Asiad gold before stepping down a few days ago, was also in attendance and presented the PM with a jersey signed by the medal-winning team. Her successor Smriti Mandhana also posed with her.

Golfer Pranavi Urs gave Prime Minister Modi her glove and a framed golf ball.

"Sankalp aur sapne ek din mein poore nahi hote (Dreams are not achieved in a day). It takes years of hard work and dedication. In the last 12 years, India has shown patience and worked hard to create a sports ecosystem," he said.

"There was a time when India would win a few medals at big events. The country did not know so many sports. We resolved to end this pessimism, and the result is our increasing representation on the global stage.

"A transparent system is in place for sports now," he added.

# We want to play fearless and smart T20 cricket: Shafali

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Raipur



The Indian women's cricket team aims to play fearless cricket while staying smart heading into the Women's Champions Trophy at home early next year, Vice Captain Shafali Verma said on Thursday.

India will take on Zimbabwe for the first time in a bilateral series, with the T20 series part of their preparations for the ICC event in February.

India and Zimbabwe will face off in a three-match T20 series here before moving to Vadodara for three ODIs.

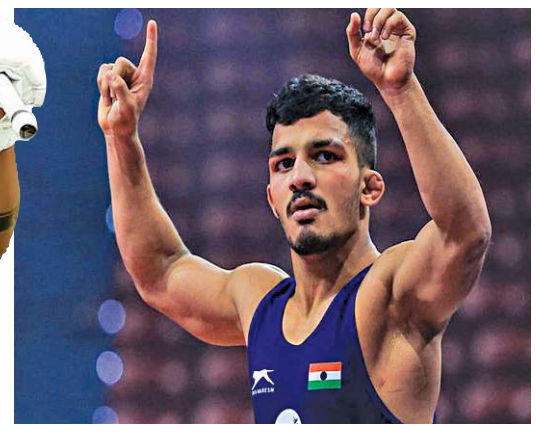
"We have spoken about it, that in this series we have to play a fearless brand of cricket with smartness till the Champions Trophy. We have done lots of meetings so everyone knows what to do. We are just trying to keep growing series by series," Shafali told reporters on the eve of the series opener.

The Indian women's team has seen a leadership change after Harmanpreet Kaur stepped down. Smriti Mandhana was appointed captain across formats, with Shafali named deputy in T20Is and Deepti Sharma in ODIs.

"Harman provided a lot of growth to women's cricket and the way it has shaped, it is all because of her," Shafali said about the former skipper. After being away from the national team last year before her recall during the ODI World Cup, Shafali said her hard work across different areas helped her.

"I analysed myself when I was out of the team. I needed to work on consistency, fitness, and mental growth. I worked hard on these things, and now everything is coming together," Shafali said.

# Vishvajit makes history, wins silver at U23 Worlds



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Las Vegas (USA)

Vishvajit More became the first Indian Greco-Roman wrestler to win a silver medal at the U23 World Championship, while Komal and Diskha Malik remain in contention for bronze. More, who already has two U23 World Championship bronze medals in his collection, was gunning for a historic gold but finished second after losing the fiercely fought final 12-13 to Georgia's Koba Karumidze.

He opened his campaign with a close 10-8 win over Mexico's Isaac Marin Mata, then beat Iranian U20 world champion Armin Shamsipour 8-1 in the quarterfinals. The semifinal against Russia's Malik Gigiev was also a close affair in which he prevailed 7-4.

The other Indian Greco-Roman wrestlers in the fray could not reach the medal round, with Chetan (63kg) losing his pre-quarterfinal and Karan Kamboj (87kg) suffering a heavy technical superiority defeat in the qualification round.

In the women's event, Komal lost her semifinal to Ukraine's Alina Filipovych by technical superiority and will now fight for bronze.

Diksha Malik (76kg) is also alive in the bronze-medal race, but Mansi Lather (68kg) bowed out after losing her quarterfinal 9-10 to Laura Godino from Italy.

# Chouhan best-placed Indian at tied fifth on weather-hit opening day

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi



Om Prakash Chouhan emerged as the best-placed Indian at tied fifth after carding a four-under 68 on the weather-hit opening day of the $4 million DP World India Championship at Delhi Golf Club here on Thursday. The day's play was disrupted by rain, resulting in a stoppage of four hours and 50 minutes. Play was eventually suspended at 5.53 pm due to darkness and will resume at 6.45 am on Friday.

The 40-year-old Chouhan picked up six birdies against two bogeys to share fifth place with five others after play was suspended on Thursday. Asian Games participant Saptak Talwar was the next-best Indian, tied 29th after carding a one-under 71.

"I'm very satisfied with my round. I had to adjust my mindset because finding the fairway is important for setting up the second shot," Chouhan said.

Speaking about the challenging holes, he said, "The ninth, 16th, 11th and 13th are challenging. Actually, every hole presents a challenge." Chouhan said his familiarity with the course helped him negotiate the layout.

"It helped because I've played Delhi Golf Club so many times and know the course well. My main plan today was to keep the ball on the fairway," he said.

Denmark's Niklas Nørgaard fired a six-under 66 to take the clubhouse lead, while Tom McKibbin, Thomas Detry and Eugenio Chacarra were tied second after carding matching five-under 67s. Seven-time Major winner Rory McIlroy and defending champion Tommy Fleetwood were tied 13th after returning identical two-under 70s. Nørgaard's round featured six birdies, an eagle and two bogeys.

"I'm very happy. A bit surprised as well," said Nørgaard, who secured two notable runner-up finishes between August and October.

"This should not suit me at all. It pretty much neutralises my best weapon: my driver. But I just managed to make no big mistakes, put the irons in play, and putt pretty well," he said.

Rain tested the patience of the golfers, with more than 70 players yet to complete their opening rounds when play was suspended due to darkness.

# It lacked common sense: Ashwin questions India's decision to drop Kuldeep Yadav

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi



Former India spinner R Ashwin has questioned the team management's decision to drop spinner Kuldeep Yadav from the playing eleven, saying it lacked common sense as his presence could have made a difference in the ongoing T20I series against the West Indies.

Kuldeep played the first two matches in Lucknow and Ranchi before being left out for the next two games in Indore and Hyderabad. The left-arm wrist spinner returned figures of 2 for 33 in the opening match but conceded 53 runs in the Ranchi match, which India lost.

India's bowling struggles continued in the fourth T20I in Hyderabad, where the West Indies scored 247 for 3 and went on to win by 24 runs after dismissing India for 223.

"It is very surprising because, on a ground where you expect to get some bounce, I know it has not always been a happy hunting ground for spinners. But the West Indies batters are struggling to pick his (Kuldeep) googly and leg-spin. So, if you are leaving Kuldeep out against them, it lacks a bit of common sense. It is very surprising because I think his presence could have made a difference of 15-20 runs," Ashwin said on his YouTube channel.

"I was surprised. Kuldeep was not picked in Indore, and I would still endorse that decision because I can understand that the ground is small," he added.

# Sports Ministry's Asiad review raises questions

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi




India's lower-than-expected medal haul in high-yielding disciplines like athletics and badminton was scrutinised at the Sports Ministry's review of the country's Asian Games performance here on Thursday, with questions raised about injured athletes travelling to the mega-event.

The meet was chaired by Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya and was attended by Minister of State for Sports Raksha Khadse, Indian Olympic Association (IOA) President P T Usha, Sports Secretary Hari Ranjan Rao, Target Olympic Podium Scheme (TOPS) CEO NS Johal and representatives of the National Sports Federations (NSFs). The review also aimed to plan ahead for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics.

India won 85 medals at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games, including 21 gold, significantly fewer than the 106 medals it won at the previous edition in Hangzhou, China.

"The Minister was very clear that there is no dearth of resources and the NSFs can no longer complain about financial support. The federations have to deliver. They have to not just make presentations but deliver on the ground," a top official present at the meeting told PTI.

# Beyond the bullseye: How India is building its Archery talent pipeline

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi/Aizwal

From a ₹3,000 bow in Amravati to a new ₹13.28-crore archery academy in Mizoram, India's Asian Games success reflects a wider effort to take the sport to more young athletes and give emerging talent the support to compete at the highest level.

For a family that makes cardboard boxes for sweet shops, ₹3,000 is no small sum. For Kumkum Anil Mohod's family, it helped buy something far more valuable than a piece of sporting equipment: a chance for their daughter to pursue a dream.

Growing up in Amravati, Maharashtra, Kumkum began archery with a modest wooden bow her grandmother helped buy. The journey that followed wasn't built in a day, but through years of practice, competition, and the determination to keep going. At 17, she reached a stage few athletes ever do. At the 2026 Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, she won the women's individual recurve gold, becoming the first Indian woman to claim the title. She had already helped India win its first-ever women's team recurve gold at the Games.

Kumkum's story is moving because of the distance between that first bow and the podium. But it also reminds us that talent often emerges long before the resources needed to nurture it are in place.

India's nine-medal archery campaign at Aichi-Nagoya-five gold, two silver and two bronze-suggests that the country's success is no longer confined to a single champion or event.

For the Archery Association of India (AAI), expanding that pathway is central to sustaining the country's recent gains. The association's structure includes national championships across sub-junior, junior, and senior categories, along with National Ranking Archery Tournaments.




With support from NTPC, the association has organised around 53 national tournaments and championships, accounting for approximately 24,096 participant entries. Support has also covered kits and uniforms for Indian archers at international competitions, with around 1,145 athlete participations recorded across 88 events.

NTPC's involvement spans both competitive exposure and longer-term development. The company began supporting archery through AAI under its corporate social responsibility programme in November 2018, with an initial commitment of ₹16.18 crore through 2025. In September 2025, the partnership was renewed for four years, with a commitment of ₹24.20 crore.

A separate agreement signed in 2022 with the National Sports Development Fund (NSDF) and the Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports committed ₹115 crore over five years for archery development. The NTPC-supported Dhanurvidya Project focuses on grassroots talent identification, academy development, coach training, scholarships, equipment and competitive exposure, including support for women and para archers. Its implementation period has been extended to March 2030.

The approach is also taking shape through new infrastructure. On 8 October, NTPC Bongaigaon signed a Memorandum of Agreement with the Mizoram State Sports Council to establish an archery academy at Lengpui in Mamit district, with a financial commitment of ₹13.28 crore over three years.

The proposed facility will provide professional coaching, modern equipment and structured training for young athletes preparing for district-, state- and national-level competitions. The state sports council will implement and maintain the academy, while NTPC Bongaigaon will provide financial assistance and monitor progress.

The Mizoram project adds a regional dimension to the wider effort: developing facilities closer to aspiring athletes and creating more opportunities to enter organised training.